ONE KINGDOM, TWO NAMES

The Kingdom of God, the Kingdom of Heaven, and the Kingdom the Prophets Promised

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September 2026

Introduction

Few questions divide Bible-believing people who otherwise agree on almost everything as sharply as this one: are "the kingdom of God" and "the kingdom of heaven" two kingdoms or one? The question is not just academic. It shapes how a person reads the Sermon on the Mount, how he understands what Jesus offered Israel, what he thinks the church is and is not, and how he expects the promises made to David to be fulfilled. Whole systems of Bible teaching have been built on the answer.

I was taught, and for a long time held without much examination, the answer given by Peter S. Ruckman in *The Sure Word of Prophecy*: the kingdom of heaven is always literal, physical, and visible, while the kingdom of God is always spiritual; the two are never the same; and any teacher who says otherwise has failed to grasp the plan of the Bible.[1] Others who teach the same position put it even more bluntly: the kingdom of God is always a spiritual kingdom, and the kingdom of heaven is always a physical kingdom on this earth. That teaching has real strengths: it takes the promises to Israel literally, refuses to let the church swallow up the kingdom, and keeps the Second Coming at the center of prophecy. Those things are right, and this paper will defend them.

But the question in front of us is narrower and has to be answered on its own terms. It is a question about two phrases and what the Bible does with them. Two things must therefore be kept apart from the start. The first is what the *expressions* "kingdom of God" and "kingdom of heaven" mean and refer to. The second is how God's kingdom actually *operates*: what was promised to Israel, what Jesus offered, what exists now in believers, and what is still to come.

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[1]Peter S. Ruckman, *The Sure Word of Prophecy* (Pensacola, FL: Bible Baptist Bookstore, 1969), e-book, chap. 4, "Conception and Development." The book was first issued under the title *The Kingdom of Heaven versus the Kingdom of God*; Ruckman notes the change of title in his commentary on Matthew 6:33. Peter S. Ruckman, *The Book of Matthew*, Bible Believer's Commentary Series (Pensacola, FL: Bible Baptist Bookstore, 1970), e-book, on Matt. 6:33.

Much of the confusion on this subject comes from letting the second question answer the first. A person who rightly sees that there is a literal Davidic kingdom still to come and a spiritual reign of Christ in believers right now naturally reaches for two labels, finds two phrases in the Gospels, and pairs them up. The pairing feels right because the two realities are real. Whether the Bible itself makes that pairing is a different matter, and it can only be settled by a deep study of the phrases as they are used in the Bible.

The conclusion this paper reaches is this. The Bible does distinguish Christ's present saving reign from His future public reign on the earth, and both must be held. But "kingdom of God" and "kingdom of heaven" are not the Bible's names for those two realities. They are two names for one kingdom. "Kingdom of God" is the broad term, used from Matthew to Revelation for the rule of God in every phase, past, present, future, and eternal, spiritual and visible. "Kingdom of heaven" is Matthew's term, used by no other writer, for that same kingdom viewed as heaven's rule coming down to the earth through David's Son. Scripture proves the identity of the two expressions by recording the same sayings of Jesus, spoken on the same occasions, under both names, and Matthew himself switches from one to the other in a single breath. Once that is seen, the real distinction the Bible draws can be stated in the Bible's own vocabulary, and stated more accurately than the two-kingdom scheme allows.

How the question will be approached

A study of this kind has to be governed by rules, or it becomes a contest of proof texts. The rules used here are plain ones, and they will be applied openly so that the reader can check the work. Context decides meaning: before asking what a verse means, one asks who is speaking, to whom, on what occasion, and what was said before and after, and a verse spoken to the Pharisees will not be made to define a term for the whole Bible until it has been read as a word to

the Pharisees. The Bible is written to Jews, Gentiles, and the church (1 Cor. 10:32), and its books and dispensations must be divided where God divides them; Matthew has Israel in view in a way Colossians does not. A passage is taken literally unless it cannot be, and that rule cuts both ways: it keeps the promises to David literal, and it keeps "the heavens do rule" (Dan. 4:26) from being explained away. The individual words are the key; where the text has "God" it means God, and where it has "heaven" it means heaven, so this paper will never treat the two *words* as interchangeable, only ask what the Bible does with the two *phrases*. No Scripture is of any private interpretation (2 Pet. 1:20); it is interpreted by "comparing spiritual things with spiritual" (1 Cor. 2:13), and where three inspired writers record the same words of Jesus spoken at the same moment, their records outrank any rule of logic brought in from outside. The Bible is consistent, so where one verse says the kingdom of God is "not meat and drink" and another has the Lord eating and drinking in it, the task is to find the reading under which both stand as written. The first mention of a subject often sets its meaning. And, most costly of all, the student must be willing to change what he has been taught when it goes against the Bible, and never bend the Bible to what he already believes. That last rule is easy to preach against someone else's tradition and hard to apply to one's own. This paper tries to apply it honestly, which means representing the position under examination in its own words and at its strongest before weighing it.

The argument throughout is built from the wording of the Bible itself. Where an observation from the underlying Hebrew, Aramaic, or Greek sheds light on that wording, it is mentioned in passing; nothing below rests on it. The argument therefore begins where these rules say it must, with the two phrases themselves: every place they occur, read in context and defined by comparing scripture with scripture, before any system is built on them.

The words themselves

"Kingdom"

The word "kingdom" in the Bible carries two related ideas, and both are needed here. It can mean the *reign* of a king, his royal authority and the act of ruling; and it can mean the *realm* over which he reigns, the territory and people subject to him. "Of his kingdom there shall be no end" (Luke 1:33) speaks of a reign; "the kingdoms of this world are become the kingdoms of our Lord" (Rev. 11:15) speaks of realms changing hands. "Thy kingdom is an everlasting kingdom, and thy dominion endureth throughout all generations" (Ps. 145:13) sets "kingdom" beside "dominion" as its own explanation. The Greek word behind "kingdom" in the Gospels (βασιλεία) and the Hebrew and Aramaic word behind it in Daniel carry the same double sense, as Thayer's lexicon notes: first "royal power, kingship, dominion, rule," and second "the territory subject to the rule of a king."[2]

Nothing in the word "kingdom" says "spiritual" or "physical." A *basileia* can be either, or both, depending on what is ruled and how. Whatever distinction there is between the two phrases will have to come from the genitives, "of God" and "of heaven," not from the noun they modify.

"Of God" and "of the heavens"

"The kingdom of God" is God's kingdom, the kingdom over which He rules. "The kingdom of heaven" is, on its face, the kingdom that belongs to heaven and comes from heaven. One observation from the original may be added in passing. Matthew's phrase is literally "the kingdom of the heavens," with "heaven" in the plural, because the Hebrew and Aramaic word for heaven has no singular; a Hebrew speaker who meant the sky, the abode of God, or God Himself said "heavens" in every case, and Matthew's Greek keeps that form. Thayer takes the phrase as

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[2]Joseph Henry Thayer, *A Greek-English Lexicon of the New Testament* (New York: American Book Company, 1889), s.v. βασιλεία.

"the kingdom which is of heavenly or divine origin and nature."[3] Neither phrase, in English or in the original, contains any instruction that the kingdom in view is invisible, or that it is material. The words leave the question open; so, studying the biblical usage, comparing scripture with scripture, will have to close it.

Where the phrases occur

The distribution of the two phrases in the Bible is itself evidence, and it should be laid out exactly.

"Kingdom of heaven" occurs thirty-three times in thirty-two verses, and every one of them is in Matthew. The count is thirty-three rather than thirty-two because Matthew 5:19 contains the phrase twice, and it is thirty-two verses rather than thirty-one because in Matthew 25:14 the words "the kingdom of heaven is" were supplied by the translators and stand in italics.

"Kingdom of God" occurs seventy times in sixty-nine verses (Luke 17:20 has it twice). Matthew has it five times (6:33; 12:28; 19:24; 21:31; 21:43), Mark fifteen, Luke thirty-three, John two, Acts seven, Romans one, 1 Corinthians four, Galatians one, Colossians one, and 2 Thessalonians one. Unlike "kingdom of heaven," it is spread across the Gospels, Acts, and the epistles, and it is the only one of the two that survives past the Gospels at all.

Neither phrase occurs anywhere in the Old Testament. The Old Testament speaks constantly of God's kingdom and of the kingdom promised to David, but it never once uses either expression. Anyone who says that Adam, Noah, or Solomon held "the crown of the kingdom of heaven" is using language the Old Testament does not use of them.

[3]Thayer, *Greek-English Lexicon*, s.v. βασιλεία.

The kingdom of heaven, passage by passage

The rules set out above require that the two phrases be defined from the places where they occur before anything is built on them, and the counts just given show what that involves: thirty-three uses of "the kingdom of heaven," all in Matthew, and seventy of "the kingdom of God." This section and the next take every one of them. Each passage is read in its own setting; the figures in it are defined by the way the Bible uses the same figures elsewhere, comparing scripture with scripture; and each use is placed in the period of history it describes. Three things are kept apart throughout: what the verse says, what the cross-references supply, and the identification that comes from putting the two together. Where the text does not name something, that is said plainly, and the identification is given as the conclusion the other scriptures support. Each passage is also read the three ways Scripture is written to be read: in the historical setting where it was spoken, in the period it describes doctrinally, and in the lesson it carries for any believer (Rom. 15:4; 1 Cor. 10:11; 2 Tim. 2:15).

"At hand": the kingdom offered to Israel (3:2; 4:17; 10:7)

"Repent ye: for the kingdom of heaven is at hand" (3:2) is the preaching of John the Baptist. "Repent: for the kingdom of heaven is at hand" (4:17) is the first preaching of Jesus after John was cast into prison. "And as ye go, preach, saying, The kingdom of heaven is at hand" (10:7) is the message of the Twelve. None of the three defines the phrase, because the hearers already had the definition. Daniel had told them that "in the days of these kings shall the God of heaven set up a kingdom, which shall never be destroyed" (Dan. 2:44), and that "the kingdom and dominion, and the greatness of the kingdom under the whole heaven, shall be given to the people of the saints of the most High" (7:27). Isaiah had placed the government "upon the throne of David, and upon his kingdom" (Isa. 9:7). It had been covenanted to David's house (2 Sam.

7:12–16), and Jeremiah had promised a righteous Branch of David, a King who "shall reign and prosper" (Jer. 23:5). "At hand" means that this kingdom had drawn near, because its King had come: "Where is he that is born King of the Jews?" (Matt. 2:2).

The audience is fixed by the text. The Twelve were told, "Go not into the way of the Gentiles, and into any city of the Samaritans enter ye not: But go rather to the lost sheep of the house of Israel" (10:5–6). The signs that went with the message (10:8) were the credentials Israel looked for, since "the Jews require a sign" (1 Cor. 1:22) and Moses had been given signs "that they may believe" (Exod. 4:5). John's baptism prepared the nation to receive its King; he came baptizing so that Christ "should be made manifest to Israel" (John 1:31). Christ Himself came as "a minister of the circumcision for the truth of God, to confirm the promises made unto the fathers" (Rom. 15:8), and the message was the kingdom itself, not yet the gospel of His death, burial, and resurrection that Paul would preach (1 Cor. 15:1–4).

Luke dates John's preaching to the fifteenth year of Tiberius Caesar (Luke 3:1–2), but the announcement itself has a second time. Malachi promised Elijah "before the coming of the great and dreadful day of the LORD" (Mal. 4:5), and after John's death Jesus still said, "Elias truly shall first come, and restore all things" (Matt. 17:11). The charge to the Twelve looks the same way: "ye shall not have gone over the cities of Israel, till the Son of man be come" (10:23). The Twelve finished their witness to Israel and the Son of man did not come, so the promise waits for "the end," the time just before the King appears (Dan. 9:26–27; Matt. 24:13–14). Before the end "this gospel of the kingdom shall be preached in all the world for a witness unto all nations; and then shall the end come" (24:14), and Revelation names the preachers: the two witnesses, and the sealed servants out of the twelve tribes (Rev. 7:3–8; 11:3–12; 14:1–5).

Definition. In these three verses the kingdom of heaven is the literal kingdom of the God of heaven, promised to Israel through David's Son, announced as near and offered to the nation at the first coming. The same announcement will be made to Israel again in the Tribulation, before the King returns. These verses, with the closely related 11:12 and 23:13, are the places where the kingdom of heaven is the kingdom offered to the nation of Israel as such. They are a handful of the thirty-three.

The constitution of the kingdom (5:3, 10, 19, 20; 7:21)

Six occurrences fall inside the Sermon on the Mount. The Sermon is the King's law for His kingdom, spoken from a mountain as the law had been given from Sinai (Exod. 19:20; Matt. 5:1), and it is set against the old giving of the law: "Ye have heard that it was said by them of old time . . . But I say unto you" (5:21–22). Its subject is the kingdom of heaven. It says nothing of the church, the new birth, the body of Christ, or the gospel of the cross, and its commandments are those of the law, quoted and deepened (5:21, 27).

"Blessed are the poor in spirit: for theirs is the kingdom of heaven" (5:3) and "Blessed are they which are persecuted for righteousness' sake: for theirs is the kingdom of heaven" (5:10) begin and end the beatitudes with the same promise, and the promises in between describe the kingdom's future character: the meek "shall inherit the earth" (5:5; cf. Ps. 37:11), and the pure in heart "shall see God" (Matt. 5:8). "Blessed" is "happy," as Leah used the word: "Happy am I" (Gen. 30:13). The poor in spirit are the broken and contrite of the Psalms (Ps. 34:18; 51:17), the man "that is poor and of a contrite spirit" to whom the LORD looks (Isa. 66:2), the poor whom God has chosen as "heirs of the kingdom which he hath promised to them that love him" (James 2:5). The kingdom is theirs now by title; they possess it when the meek inherit the earth. The persecution of 5:10 is defined in the next verse as persecution "for my sake" (Matt. 5:11). The

righteousness is Christ Himself (Rom. 10:4), and the apostles found it so when they were forbidden to speak in His name and beaten for it (Acts 4:18; 5:40).

"Whosoever therefore shall break one of these least commandments, and shall teach men so, he shall be called the least in the kingdom of heaven: but whosoever shall do and teach them, the same shall be called great in the kingdom of heaven" (5:19). The kingdom in this verse has ranks, least and great, and a law that stands "till heaven and earth pass" (5:18). That is a kingdom on the earth under a King who will "rule them with a rod of iron" (Rev. 2:27; 19:15; cf. Ps. 2:9), when "out of Zion shall go forth the law" (Isa. 2:3). The commandments in view are the ten (Matt. 5:21, 27). They still judge the unbelieving (John 12:48; Rom. 2:15–16), though the believer of this age is "not under the law, but under grace" (Rom. 6:14).

"For I say unto you, That except your righteousness shall exceed the righteousness of the scribes and Pharisees, ye shall in no case enter into the kingdom of heaven" (5:20). The scribes and Pharisees were the strictest keepers of the law in Israel (Phil. 3:5–6; Luke 18:11–12), and the standard is set above them. The King is searching hearts as Malachi said He would when He comes as a refiner (Mal. 3:2–5), and the Pharisees answer to most of the sins Malachi names. No man has such righteousness of himself, for "by the deeds of the law there shall no flesh be justified in his sight" (Rom. 3:20). The only righteousness that exceeds the Pharisees' is the one God supplies: "not having mine own righteousness, which is of the law, but that which is through the faith of Christ" (Phil. 3:9), so "that the righteousness of the law might be fulfilled in us" (Rom. 8:4).

"Not every one that saith unto me, Lord, Lord, shall enter into the kingdom of heaven; but he that doeth the will of my Father which is in heaven" (7:21). The entrance is decided "in that day" (7:22), the prophets' phrase for the day of the LORD's coming (Isa. 4:2; 10:20), when

the King comes in His glory at the end of the Tribulation and judges (Matt. 25:31–46; 2 Thess. 1:7–10). The Son Himself states the Father's will: "this is the will of him that sent me, that every one which seeth the Son, and believeth on him, may have everlasting life" (John 6:40). Those turned away had prophesied, cast out devils, and done "many wonderful works" in His name (Matt. 7:22). They are professors of His name without life from Him, the same false prophets in sheep's clothing the Sermon has just exposed (7:15). Scripture shows how far such men can go: the sons of Sceva used the name of Jesus over devils (Acts 19:13–15), and Judas, of whom the Lord said "one of you is a devil" (John 6:70), was among the Twelve sent to cast them out (Matt. 10:1–8).

Definition. In the Sermon on the Mount the kingdom of heaven is the King's coming kingdom on the earth, described by its law, its ranks, and its conditions of entrance. Historically the Sermon was spoken to Israel under the law at the first coming, while the kingdom was being offered; doctrinally it is the law of the kingdom when the King reigns, with its warnings falling on the professors refused "in that day"; devotionally its principles reach anyone who would belong to the King. Even here the phrase reaches beyond a national birthright: entrance requires a righteousness Israel's best men did not have, it is refused to many who call Jesus "Lord," and it is settled at the judgment of 7:22–23.

Gentiles at Abraham's table (8:11)

"And I say unto you, That many shall come from the east and west, and shall sit down with Abraham, and Isaac, and Jacob, in the kingdom of heaven. But the children of the kingdom shall be cast out into outer darkness: there shall be weeping and gnashing of teeth" (8:11–12). The occasion is a Gentile, a Roman centurion, whose faith Jesus had not found "in Israel" (8:10). The "many" from the east and west are Gentiles, gathered as the prophets said they would be:

"these shall come from far: and, lo, these from the north and from the west" (Isa. 49:12); "my name shall be great among the Gentiles" (Mal. 1:11). Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob are present in person, so the scene follows "the resurrection of the just" (Luke 14:14). "The children of the kingdom" (Matt. 8:12), the natural heirs, are the unbelieving in Israel, and they are cast out (cf. Luke 13:28). Matthew has been preparing for this from his first page: Gentile women stand in the King's genealogy (Matt. 1:3, 5), and wise men from the east were the first to worship Him (2:1–2).

Definition. Here the kingdom of heaven is the King's future kingdom on the earth after the resurrection of the just, with the patriarchs at its table: the millennial kingdom, when the redeemed "shall reign on the earth" (Rev. 5:10; 20:4–6). Its company includes believing Gentiles from the ends of the earth and excludes unbelieving sons of the kingdom. This is the first use in Matthew that shows plainly the phrase is not limited to the Jewish nation.

John, the least, and the violent (11:11–12)

"Verily I say unto you, Among them that are born of women there hath not risen a greater than John the Baptist: notwithstanding he that is least in the kingdom of heaven is greater than he" (11:11). John was the last of the prophets, "For all the prophets and the law prophesied until John" (11:13), and he was the messenger of Malachi 3:1 sent before the King's face (11:10). The comparison is one of position, not character. Those who enter are born of God, not merely "born of women" (John 1:13; 1 Pet. 1:23), and the kingdom they enter is the one the prophets described (Isa. 11; Zech. 13), with the risen King present and the earth renewed "in the regeneration" (Matt. 19:28). John stood at the door of that kingdom and announced it; its least member stands where the herald at the door had not yet stood.

"And from the days of John the Baptist until now the kingdom of heaven suffereth violence, and the violent take it by force" (11:12). Two readings have support in the text, and both may be in view. The first is the violence of men pressing in: publicans, harlots, and soldiers forced their way in by submitting to John's hard message while the leaders held back (Luke 3:12–14; 16:16; Matt. 21:32), and the crowd that would "take him by force, to make him a king" shows what the words mean (John 6:15). The second is the violence of usurpers: the chief priests and Pharisees held the vineyard and plotted to seize the heir's inheritance (Matt. 21:38, 43–45), as Herod and the council had already tried to destroy the King (2:13–16; 12:14). The verses also divide the kingdom's history: "all the prophets and the law prophesied until John" (11:13); from John "until now" it was preached and resisted (11:12); and its fulness waits for the coming in which many shall sit down with Abraham (8:11).

Definition. In Matthew 11 the kingdom of heaven is the kingdom of the prophets as it stood at the first coming: announced since John, pressed into by repentant sinners, and grasped at by usurpers. Its least member, once it is established, will stand above the greatest prophet before it. The period is the first coming, "from the days of John the Baptist until now," with the kingdom's establishment still future.

The mysteries of the kingdom of heaven (13:11, 24, 31, 33, 44, 45, 47, 52)

Matthew 12 sets the stage. The Son of David proves Himself with signs (12:22–23); the Pharisees hold "a council against him, how they might destroy him" (12:14) and credit His power to Beelzebub (12:24); Isaiah's word that "in his name shall the Gentiles trust" is quoted (12:21); the men of Nineveh and the queen of the south are named as Gentile witnesses against that generation (12:41–42); and the King owns as His family only those who do His Father's will (12:49–50). Then "The same day went Jesus out of the house, and sat by the sea side" (13:1), and

He began to speak in parables. The house was Israel's, and He would later leave it "desolate" (23:38). The sea is Scripture's figure for the nations: "The waters which thou sawest . . . are peoples, and multitudes, and nations, and tongues" (Rev. 17:15; cf. Isa. 60:5). The setting marks the turn. Rejected by His own house, the King speaks from the shore of the nations.

"It is given unto you to know the mysteries of the kingdom of heaven, but to them it is not given" (13:11). A mystery in the New Testament is a truth "kept secret since the world began, but now is made manifest" (Rom. 16:25–26), "hid from ages and from generations, but now is made manifest to his saints" (Col. 1:26). Matthew says the parables fulfilled the word, "I will utter things which have been kept secret from the foundation of the world" (Matt. 13:35). The prophets had seen the King and His kingdom. They had not seen a long age between His rejection and His return in which the word of the kingdom would be sown among the nations, and that age is what these parables describe. Jesus fixes its limits Himself. It begins with the Son of man sowing the good seed (13:37), and it ends with the harvest, which "is the end of the world" (13:39), when the angels gather out the wicked: "Then shall the righteous shine forth as the sun in the kingdom of their Father" (13:43). Everything in these parables falls between the first coming and the second; "the end of the world" is the end of this present age, as Paul speaks of "this present evil world" (Gal. 1:4). Isaiah's sentence of blindness, quoted here (13:14–15), was quoted again when the Jews of Rome refused the risen King at the close of Acts (Acts 28:25–28), and the mystery form fills the age that follows, until the King comes. They describe what the kingdom of heaven would be in the world while the King was absent: the whole sphere in which His name is professed, which history calls Christendom. The later parables of the chapter also follow the course of the churches of Revelation 2–3: the leaven matches Thyatira, where "that woman Jezebel" teaches (Rev. 2:20); the hidden treasure matches Sardis; and the pearl and

the net can be read of Philadelphia and Laodicea. Five more kingdom-of-heaven parables follow later in Matthew (18:23; 20:1; 22:2; 25:1, 14), twelve in all, the number of Israel.

The sower (13:3–23) comes first, and Jesus interprets it. The sower is Christ, for Luke calls the seed "his seed" and says, "The seed is the word of God" (Luke 8:5, 11); in Matthew it is "the word of the kingdom" (13:19). The fowls that devour the wayside seed (13:4) are "the wicked one," who "catcheth away that which was sown" (13:19). The stony-ground hearer endures "for a while" and falls away under persecution (13:21); the thorny-ground hearer is choked by "the care of this world, and the deceitfulness of riches" (13:22); only the good ground bears fruit (13:23). The four grounds are four kinds of profession: the careless, the temporary, the worldly, and the sincere. From the outset the kingdom in mystery is a field where most of the sowing comes to nothing.

The wheat and the tares. "The kingdom of heaven is likened unto a man which sowed good seed in his field: But while men slept, his enemy came and sowed tares among the wheat, and went his way" (13:24–25). Jesus gives the definitions: "He that soweth the good seed is the Son of man; The field is the world; the good seed are the children of the kingdom; but the tares are the children of the wicked one; The enemy that sowed them is the devil; the harvest is the end of the world; and the reapers are the angels" (13:37–39). The tares are sown "among the wheat," in the same field, and they are left alone "lest while ye gather up the tares, ye root up also the wheat with them" (13:29); until the harvest they cannot safely be told apart. That is a picture of counterfeit believers sown inside the profession of Christ's name. They are the devil's imitation of the children of God, like the "mixed multitude" that came out of Egypt with Israel (Exod. 12:38). The good seed are true children, born "of incorruptible" seed, "by the word of God" (1 Pet. 1:23). Paul warned that "of your own selves shall men arise, speaking perverse

things" (Acts 20:30), and spoke of "false apostles, deceitful workers, transforming themselves into the apostles of Christ" (2 Cor. 11:13); Peter, that "there shall be false teachers among you, who privily shall bring in damnable heresies" (2 Pet. 2:1); Jude, that "there are certain men crept in unawares" (Jude 4). The tares came "while men slept." The Man who sowed did not sleep, but those set over the field did, the condition the apostle warns against: "let us not sleep, as do others; but let us watch and be sober" (1 Thess. 5:6). At the harvest the tares are gathered "first" and bound "in bundles" (Matt. 13:30), the lost drawn together before the burning, as the prophets saw the nations gathered for judgment (Zeph. 3:8; Zech. 14:2). The angels "shall gather out of his kingdom all things that offend, and them which do iniquity" (Matt. 13:41), and the field becomes the kingdom of the Son of man when heaven announces, "The kingdoms of this world are become the kingdoms of our Lord, and of his Christ" (Rev. 11:15). Then "shall the righteous shine forth as the sun" (Matt. 13:43), the language the prophets use for the King's appearing and reign (Mal. 4:2; Dan. 12:3).

The mustard seed. "The kingdom of heaven is like to a grain of mustard seed, which a man took, and sowed in his field: Which indeed is the least of all seeds: but when it is grown, it is the greatest among herbs, and becometh a tree, so that the birds of the air come and lodge in the branches thereof" (13:31–32). Scripture defines the seed: "If ye have faith as a grain of mustard seed" (17:20). Here the seed of faith is sown "in his field," and "The field is the world" (13:38). A mustard plant is an herb, but this one "becometh a tree," and Scripture uses trees for kings and kingdoms (Judg. 9:8–15; Ezek. 17:22–24; 31:3–9). Nebuchadnezzar's kingdom was a tree whose "height thereof reached unto heaven," with "the fowls of the heaven" in its boughs (Dan. 4:11–12, 20–22); the Assyrian was a cedar in whose boughs "All the fowls of heaven made their nests" (Ezek. 31:6). The birds have been defined in this chapter: the fowls that devour

the seed are "the wicked one" (Matt. 13:4, 19; cf. Luke 8:5, 12), and at the end Babylon is "the hold of every foul spirit, and a cage of every unclean and hateful bird" (Rev. 18:2). The faith sown in the world would grow out of its nature into a great worldly religious power, a tree like Babylon's, with unclean spirits lodging in its branches, the departure in which men give "heed to seducing spirits, and doctrines of devils" (1 Tim. 4:1). In history the tree is the professing church grown worldly and Roman, holding out to the world a faith that shelters what God calls unclean. At the end little true faith will remain: "when the Son of man cometh, shall he find faith on the earth?" (Luke 18:8).

The leaven. "Another parable spake he unto them; The kingdom of heaven is like unto leaven, which a woman took, and hid in three measures of meal, till the whole was leavened" (13:33). Every figure in the verse is defined elsewhere in Scripture.

Leaven had to be put out of every house at the Passover: "whosoever eateth that which is leavened, even that soul shall be cut off from the congregation of Israel" (Exod. 12:19). No meat offering to the LORD could contain it: "ye shall burn no leaven, nor any honey, in any offering of the LORD made by fire" (Lev. 2:11). Jesus defined it Himself. "Take heed and beware of the leaven of the Pharisees and of the Sadducees," He said, and the disciples understood "how that he bade them not beware of the leaven of bread, but of the doctrine of the Pharisees and of the Sadducees" (Matt. 16:6, 12). Luke records "the leaven of the Pharisees, which is hypocrisy" (Luke 12:1), and Mark "the leaven of Herod" (Mark 8:15). Paul set "the leaven of malice and wickedness" against "the unleavened bread of sincerity and truth" (1 Cor. 5:8) and twice warned that "a little leaven leaveneth the whole lump" (1 Cor. 5:6; Gal. 5:9), the second time about false doctrine troubling the churches of Galatia. The leaven of the Pharisees and Sadducees is named in the Gospels and Acts: calling men "father" in religion (Matt. 23:9), long prayers made "for a

pretence" (23:14), long robes (23:5; Mark 12:38), tradition set above the word (Mark 7:6–13), and denial of the resurrection and of angels (Acts 23:8). The word of God is milk, meat, bread, and honey (1 Pet. 2:2; Heb. 5:12–14; Matt. 4:4; Ps. 19:10), never sour dough. The law also shows where leaven may be found. The bread that pictures Christ is unleavened (Lev. 23:6; 1 Cor. 5:7–8), and no leaven may go into the meat offering anointed with oil, the figure of the Holy Spirit (Lev. 2:1, 11); yet leavened bread was accepted from the worshipper with his thanksgiving (Lev. 7:13), and the loaves of Pentecost were "baken with leaven" (Lev. 23:17). Leaven may be found among God's own people. Nowhere in Scripture does it picture the gospel or the kingdom's goodness; it pictures false doctrine, working quietly until it has gone through everything.

The meal. Meal is ground from wheat, and the wheat of this chapter has been defined: "the good seed are the children of the kingdom" (13:38). Paul calls a church of such people a lump and tells them, "Purge out therefore the old leaven, that ye may be a new lump" (1 Cor. 5:7). The three measures of meal, then, are the professing body of the King's people in the world. In the history of Christendom that body stands in three great divisions, Roman Catholic, Greek Orthodox, and Protestant, and the parable says the leaven would be worked into all three.

The woman. The text does not name her, but Scripture defines her. The true church is never called "a woman"; she is the bride, "the Lamb's wife" (Rev. 21:9), presented "as a chaste virgin to Christ" (2 Cor. 11:2). The women of religious corruption are named. At Thyatira it was "that woman Jezebel, which calleth herself a prophetess, to teach and to seduce my servants to commit fornication, and to eat things sacrificed unto idols" (Rev. 2:20). At the end of the age it is "the great whore that sitteth upon many waters" (17:1), holding "a golden cup in her hand full of abominations" (17:4), "drunken with the blood of the saints, and with the blood of the martyrs of

Jesus" (17:6), with her name written on her forehead: "MYSTERY, BABYLON THE GREAT, THE MOTHER OF HARLOTS AND ABOMINATIONS OF THE EARTH" (17:5). She sits on "seven mountains" (17:9), and she is "that great city, which reigneth over the kings of the earth" (17:18); in John's day that city was Rome. Proverbs had drawn the type in the foolish woman who says, "Stolen waters are sweet, and bread eaten in secret is pleasant" (Prov. 9:17). A woman robed in purple and scarlet, seated on seven mountains, drunk with the blood of the saints, and reigning over the kings of the earth answers to the papal Roman church, as the Reformers read the chapter.

Hid. The woman "hid" the leaven. False teachers "privily shall bring in damnable heresies" (2 Pet. 2:1); there were "false brethren unawares brought in, who came in privily" (Gal. 2:4). The corruption does not announce itself.

"Till the whole was leavened." The process runs to the end of the age. "Evil men and seducers shall wax worse and worse, deceiving, and being deceived" (2 Tim. 3:13); "the time will come when they will not endure sound doctrine" (4:3); the day of Christ will not come "except there come a falling away first" (2 Thess. 2:3). The Lord Himself asked, "when the Son of man cometh, shall he find faith on the earth?" (Luke 18:8). The last church He addresses thinks itself "rich, and increased with goods," while He stands outside at the door and knocks (Rev. 3:17, 20).

Put together, the parable explains itself. During the King's absence a false religious system, the woman, would work false doctrine, the leaven, secretly into the professing body of the children of the kingdom, the meal, until by the time of His return every branch of professing Christendom was corrupted by it. In the history of Christendom that system is the apostate church that grew up inside the profession of Christ's name and seated itself in Rome, the Roman

Catholic system, which Revelation calls "the mother of harlots" (Rev. 17:5) because it has daughters of its own kind. Luke records the same parable under "the kingdom of God" (Luke 13:20–21), and the warning reaches further still: false doctrine works even among the truly born again, as the churches of Corinth and Galatia show (1 Cor. 5:6; Gal. 5:9).

The hidden treasure. "Again, the kingdom of heaven is like unto treasure hid in a field; the which when a man hath found, he hideth, and for joy thereof goeth and selleth all that he hath, and buyeth that field" (13:44). The field has been defined: "The field is the world" (13:38). God named His treasure at Sinai: "ye shall be a peculiar treasure unto me above all people" (Exod. 19:5); "the LORD hath chosen Jacob unto himself, and Israel for his peculiar treasure" (Ps. 135:4). The man is the Son of man, who "for the joy that was set before him endured the cross" (Heb. 12:2) and paid for the whole field, for He is "the propitiation for our sins: and not for ours only, but also for the sins of the whole world" (1 John 2:2). He bought the world itself with His blood; even false teachers deny "the Lord that bought them" (2 Pet. 2:1), and the field becomes His kingdom at Revelation 11:15. Having found the treasure, "he hideth," and the verb has no object: He hides the treasure, or He hides Himself. God had said of Israel, "I will hide my face from them" (Deut. 31:17), and promised, "In a little wrath I hid my face from thee for a moment; but with everlasting kindness will I have mercy on thee" (Isa. 54:8). Through the whole age Israel lies scattered and hidden in the field, "the twelve tribes which are scattered abroad" (James 1:1), under a "blindness in part . . . until the fulness of the Gentiles be come in" (Rom. 11:25). Somewhere in the field a true remnant of believing Israel lies hidden through the whole age, bought but not yet taken up, until "all Israel shall be saved" (11:26). In the course of the churches the parable answers to Sardis, where the Lord still had "a few names" who had "not defiled their garments" (Rev. 3:4).

The pearl of great price. "Again, the kingdom of heaven is like unto a merchant man, seeking goodly pearls: Who, when he had found one pearl of great price, went and sold all that he had, and bought it" (13:45–46). The merchant is the same buyer as before, the Son of man, who "is come to seek and to save that which was lost" (Luke 19:10). The pearl is one, bought with all He had, and Scripture names what He bought with His own blood: "the church of God, which he hath purchased with his own blood" (Acts 20:28); "Christ also loved the church, and gave himself for it" (Eph. 5:25). Precious stones in Scripture picture people: believers are "lively stones" (1 Pet. 2:5), and the LORD will make up His "jewels" (Mal. 3:17). Of all precious stones the pearl alone is formed by a living creature; it cannot be divided without being destroyed; it grows in the depths, around a wound; and kings wear it. So the church is one living body that cannot be divided (1 Cor. 12:12–13); her members are drawn up out of the depths by fishers of men (Luke 5:10), covered with a righteousness that cost the Saviour His wounds, and made "kings and priests unto God" (Rev. 1:6). The Man is Christ, the pearl is the church, and the price is His blood. In the course of the churches the pearl can be read of Philadelphia, before which the Lord set "an open door" (Rev. 3:8).

The net. "Again, the kingdom of heaven is like unto a net, that was cast into the sea, and gathered of every kind: Which, when it was full, they drew to shore, and sat down, and gathered the good into vessels, but cast the bad away. So shall it be at the end of the world: the angels shall come forth, and sever the wicked from among the just" (13:47–49). The net is cast into the sea of nations and gathers "of every kind," as the disciples were made "fishers of men" (4:19); the good and bad fish are "the just" and "the wicked" (13:49), men taken like fishes in a net (Eccl. 9:12). It is drawn to shore "when it was full," the point Paul calls "the fulness of the Gentiles" (Rom. 11:25). The sorting is done "at the end of the world," the end of the age (cf.

Heb. 9:26), and those who sort are called angels (Matt. 13:49); the saints who "shall judge the world" are to be "as the angels" and will come with the Lord when He is revealed (1 Cor. 6:2; Matt. 22:30; 2 Thess. 1:7). The wicked are cast "into the furnace of fire" (Matt. 13:50). This is the separation the King makes when He sits on the throne of His glory and before Him are gathered "all nations . . . as a shepherd divideth his sheep from the goats" (25:31–32). In the course of the churches the net may be read of Laodicea, the last of the seven (Rev. 3:14–22).

The last three parables were spoken privately to the disciples in the house (13:36), and they take up the three classes Paul names, "the Jews," "the Gentiles," and "the church of God" (1 Cor. 10:32): God's treasure Israel, hidden in the field through the age; the one pearl, the church, bought out of the sea of nations; and the net drawn through all the nations and emptied at the end.

The householder. "Therefore every scribe which is instructed unto the kingdom of heaven is like unto a man that is an householder, which bringeth forth out of his treasure things new and old" (13:52). The disciples had answered, "Yea, Lord" (13:51), though there was more they could not yet bear (John 16:12). There are good scribes, like Ezra, "a ready scribe in the law of Moses" (Ezra 7:6), as well as the scribes of Matthew 23. The householder is a steward over the house (Heb. 3:5; Luke 12:42), and his treasure is "the good treasure of the heart" (Matt. 12:35). Things "new and old" are the New and the Old together, each opening the other: the kingdom the prophets promised and the mysteries "kept secret from the foundation of the world." Paul calls the apostles "stewards of the mysteries of God" (1 Cor. 4:1).

Definition. In Matthew 13 the kingdom of heaven is the kingdom in its mystery form: the whole sphere on earth in which the word of the kingdom is sown and the King's name professed, from His first coming to the end of the world. It holds the true and the false together: the good

seed and the devil's tares, the mustard tree with unclean birds in its branches, the leaven worked into the meal by the false church, God's hidden treasure Israel, the pearl that is the church, and the full net drawn at the end. Its time is the age between the advents, the age of Christendom, traced through the same course as the churches of Revelation 2–3; its place is "the world" (13:38); its people are Jew and Gentile alike. Whatever this is, it is not a Jewish national kingdom on the earth, and Matthew calls it by no other name than "the kingdom of heaven."

The keys of the kingdom of heaven (16:19)

"And I will give unto thee the keys of the kingdom of heaven: and whatsoever thou shalt bind on earth shall be bound in heaven: and whatsoever thou shalt loose on earth shall be loosed in heaven" (16:19). The keys are given to Peter alone, in the same breath as "upon this rock I will build my church" (16:18). Keys open doors, and Scripture calls the opportunity to publish the gospel a door: "a great door and effectual is opened unto me" (1 Cor. 16:9); "a door was opened unto me of the Lord" (2 Cor. 2:12). The keys are plural, and Acts records Peter opening the door of faith to the Jew and then to the Gentile. At Pentecost he preached to "Ye men of Israel" (Acts 2:22), and "the same day there were added unto them about three thousand souls" (2:41); in Jerusalem the door was also a renewed offer to the nation, "Repent ye therefore, and be converted . . . And he shall send Jesus Christ" (3:19–20), which the nation's rulers refused (4:1–3; 7:54–59). When Samaria received the word, the apostles "sent unto them Peter and John" (8:14–17). At Caesarea Peter preached to the house of Cornelius, and "on the Gentiles also was poured out the gift of the Holy Ghost" (10:45); afterward he said that "God made choice among us, that the Gentiles by my mouth should hear the word of the gospel, and believe" (15:7), and Paul and Barnabas reported that God "had opened the door of faith unto the Gentiles" (14:27). The binding and loosing appear in Acts when Matthias was chosen (1:15–26) and when the

church settled what would be required of the Gentiles (15:19–29). In the sense of 18:18, any believer may declare forgiveness to the man who believes, on the ground of Acts 13:38–39, or warn the man who will not believe that he will "die in your sins" (John 8:24).

Definition. In 16:19 the kingdom of heaven is the kingdom whose door of faith was opened by apostolic preaching after the resurrection: offered again to Israel at Pentecost, then opened to Samaria and to the Gentiles. The time is the first chapters of Acts. The keys were used for the Jew and for the Gentile, and the second door was not Jewish.

Greatness, conversion, and children (18:1, 3, 4; 19:14)

"At the same time came the disciples unto Jesus, saying, Who is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven?" (18:1). The disciples expected the kingdom covenanted to Israel, with ranks in it, and Jesus did not correct that expectation; He told them who would be great in it. "Verily I say unto you, Except ye be converted, and become as little children, ye shall not enter into the kingdom of heaven. Whosoever therefore shall humble himself as this little child, the same is greatest in the kingdom of heaven" (18:3–4). To be converted is to be changed, not merely to turn: Judas "repented himself" (27:3) and was never converted. In every age conversion is a man's personal conversion to Christ, receiving Him and being born of God (John 1:12–13; 5:40), and the conversion comes before the humility. The humility is the mark of the true convert in any age: the Old Testament saint (Ps. 131:1–2), the disciple of the Gospels (Luke 10:21), and the Christian (Rom. 12:16; 1 Pet. 2:1–2). To receive one such little one is to receive the King (Matt. 18:5), a principle He applies again in His judgment of the nations (25:40). When the mother of Zebedee's children asked for the two places beside His throne (20:21), He answered that the great are the ones who serve (20:26–28).

"But Jesus said, Suffer little children, and forbid them not, to come unto me: for of such is the kingdom of heaven" (19:14). The kingdom is made up of people like these: the childlike, who come to Him and are not turned away. The children are brought to Him, not to a rite (19:13–15).

Definition. In Matthew 18 and 19:14 the kingdom of heaven is, doctrinally, the King's coming kingdom, the reign promised over "the house of Jacob" (Luke 1:33), whose order of greatness will be shown when He comes in His kingdom (Matt. 16:27–28; 20:21–23) and whose "little ones" are received or offended before the judgment of the nations (25:31–46). Historically the words were spoken to Jewish disciples before the cross; devotionally they bind every age, for no one enters without being converted to Christ and made humble like a child. Entrance is by a changed heart, not by a nation's birthright.

The King's reckoning with His servants (18:23)

"Therefore is the kingdom of heaven likened unto a certain king, which would take account of his servants" (18:23). Peter had asked how often to forgive (18:21), and the parable answers him. A servant forgiven ten thousand talents seizes a fellowservant who owes a hundred pence, and his lord "was wroth, and delivered him to the tormentors, till he should pay all that was due unto him. So likewise shall my heavenly Father do also unto you, if ye from your hearts forgive not every one his brother their trespasses" (18:34–35). The king's taking account is the same reckoning the Lord makes "After a long time" with His servants (25:19), for "every one of us shall give account of himself to God" (Rom. 14:12). Placed in the Tribulation, the tormentors are explained by Revelation 9, where men are "tormented five months" (Rev. 9:5). Placed in the church age, they would contradict the cross, for "all that was due" from the believer was paid at

Calvary (Col. 2:13–14; Gal. 3:13; Acts 13:38–39); in this age fire tries a believer's works, not his person (1 Cor. 3:13–15).

The terms of forgiveness are the terms of the Sermon: "if ye forgive not men their trespasses, neither will your Father forgive your trespasses" (6:15). The Christian is given the reverse order: "forgiving one another, even as God for Christ's sake hath forgiven you" (Eph. 4:32). Rightly divided, the parable's conditional forgiveness belongs to the kingdom's law as the King will administer it to His servants at His coming. Its lesson binds every forgiven man in every age: a man forgiven a debt he could never pay cannot refuse to forgive a small one. The "brother" in these chapters is the Jewish disciple before the cross (Matt. 5:22; 12:49), and the practical lesson is Luke's: "Be ye therefore merciful" (Luke 6:36).

Definition. Here the kingdom of heaven is the King's dominion over His servants under the kingdom's law of forgiveness (6:14–15), pictured at the moment He takes account of them. Historically the parable was spoken to Jews under the law before the cross; doctrinally it fits the servants of the Tribulation, reckoned with at His return (25:19); devotionally it binds every forgiven man to forgive.

Eunuchs for the kingdom of heaven's sake (19:12)

"For there are some eunuchs, which were so born from their mother's womb: and there are some eunuchs, which were made eunuchs of men: and there be eunuchs, which have made themselves eunuchs for the kingdom of heaven's sake. He that is able to receive it, let him receive it" (19:12). After hearing the King's law of marriage (19:3–9), the disciples said, "it is not good to marry" (19:10). Jesus answers that some are eunuchs by birth, some by the hand of men, and some by their own self-control for the kingdom's sake. Marriage is a physical union, and a eunuch of any kind cannot have children. "He that is able to receive it" may stay unmarried, as

Paul says, "It is good for a man not to touch a woman" (1 Cor. 7:1); yet "every man hath his proper gift of God" (7:7), and "Whoso findeth a wife findeth a good thing" (Prov. 18:22).

Definition. Here the kingdom of heaven is the cause a man may serve by giving up marriage. Historically the word was spoken to the disciples on the road to Jerusalem; the principle stands wherever the King's work is done, and Paul applies it to the believer of this age (1 Cor. 7:32–35).

The rich man and the needle's eye (19:23)

"Then said Jesus unto his disciples, Verily I say unto you, That a rich man shall hardly enter into the kingdom of heaven" (19:23). The rich young ruler had asked, "what good thing shall I do, that I may have eternal life?" (19:16), and gone away sorrowful (19:22). The next sentence repeats the warning under the other name (19:24), and the disciples ask, "Who then can be saved?" (19:25). The answer, "With men this is impossible; but with God all things are possible" (19:26), puts entrance wholly in God's hands. Peter then asks what the Twelve will have, and Jesus answers with the kingdom's future form: "in the regeneration when the Son of man shall sit in the throne of his glory, ye also shall sit upon twelve thrones, judging the twelve tribes of Israel," and "every one that hath forsaken houses . . . shall receive an hundredfold, and shall inherit everlasting life" (19:28–29). Riches stand in the way because they choke faith, hinder humility, and magnify the world (13:22; 1 John 2:16), and the disciples were "exceedingly amazed" (Matt. 19:25) because they reasoned, as Job's friends did, that prosperity proves God's favour. "The regeneration" occurs only here and in Titus 3:5: there the new birth of the believer, here the new birth of the earth when the King returns. "The throne of his glory" is David's throne (25:31; Luke 1:32; Acts 2:30).

Definition. In 19:23 the kingdom of heaven is the kingdom whose entrance is salvation and eternal life (19:16, 25) and whose glory is "the regeneration," the new birth of the earth at the Second Coming, when the King reigns from the throne of His glory with the Twelve over Israel's tribes (19:28; Rev. 20:4). Its entrance is open now to any man God saves; its glory is the millennial reign.

The labourers in the vineyard (20:1)

"For the kingdom of heaven is like unto a man that is an householder, which went out early in the morning to hire labourers into his vineyard" (20:1). The "For" ties the parable to Peter's question, "what shall we have therefore?" (19:27), and to the saying "many that are first shall be last; and the last shall be first" (19:30), which the parable ends by reversing (20:16). The householder is the Lord of the house (Heb. 3:1–6), and the vineyard is the one Scripture defines (Isa. 5:1–7; Matt. 21:33). The labourers hired "early in the morning" are the apostles who had left all (19:27), so the working day begins with them and runs to "even," when the lord calls the labourers and gives them their hire, "beginning from the last unto the first" (20:8). The hours of hiring cover the whole age of the King's absence, from the first labourers to the last hired before He comes. The first labourers bore "the burden and heat of the day" under the persecutions of the first centuries (20:12); the last labour under opposition more subtle and more constant. All receive what was promised, "whatsoever is right" (20:4, 7), from the One of whom it is asked, "Shall not the Judge of all the earth do right?" (Gen. 18:25), and who says, "Is it not lawful for me to do what I will with mine own?" (Matt. 20:15). The night is coming, "when no man can work" (John 9:4).

Definition. Here the kingdom of heaven is the kingdom in its mystery form: the King's work and workers through the whole age, from the apostles to the last hour before His return,

with rewards paid at evening before the judgment seat of Christ (2 Cor. 5:10). The verses that follow, the Son's journey to Jerusalem and the request for places "in thy kingdom" (Matt. 20:17–21), point the payment to His coming.

The marriage of the king's son (22:2)

"The kingdom of heaven is like unto a certain king, which made a marriage for his son" (22:2). The King is God the Father, the Son is Jesus, the bride is the church, and the feast is a real feast (26:29; Luke 22:30; 12:35–38). Historically the parable describes what was happening in the King's own ministry. The first servants call "them that were bidden," and "they would not come" (Matt. 22:3), as Israel had long "mocked the messengers of God" (2 Chron. 36:16). Other servants follow with the word that "all things are ready" (Matt. 22:4): the messengers of the first coming and the apostles after it, who were treated "spitefully" and slain (22:6), as the council beat the apostles and Herod killed James (Acts 5:40; 12:1–2). "But when the king heard thereof, he was wroth: and he sent forth his armies, and destroyed those murderers, and burned up their city" (Matt. 22:7). Daniel had said that after Messiah was cut off "the people of the prince that shall come shall destroy the city and the sanctuary" (Dan. 9:26), and Jerusalem was burned in A.D. 70, the judgment already announced in the parable before this one (Matt. 21:41).

Then the king says, "The wedding is ready, but they which were bidden were not worthy. Go ye therefore into the highways, and as many as ye shall find, bid to the marriage" (22:8–9). Here the parable passes over the church age in silence, for the church was a mystery not yet revealed (Eph. 3:3–10). The guests are not the bride. The Lamb's wife "hath made herself ready" (Rev. 19:7) and is presented "as a chaste virgin to Christ" (2 Cor. 11:2); the guests are many, distinct from her as the friend of the bridegroom is (John 3:29) and as the virgins of Matthew 25 are. The last servants gather "all as many as they found, both bad and good" (Matt. 22:10) in the

time of Jacob's trouble, the days of Matthew 24:13–20, when the servants of God out of Israel are sealed and a great multitude stands clothed in white robes (Rev. 7:3–9; 6:11). "Blessed are they which are called unto the marriage supper of the Lamb" (Rev. 19:9).

"And when the king came in to see the guests, he saw there a man which had not on a wedding garment: And he saith unto him, Friend, how camest thou in hither not having a wedding garment? And he was speechless. Then said the king to the servants, Bind him hand and foot, and take him away, and cast him into outer darkness; there shall be weeping and gnashing of teeth" (22:11–13). The garment is defined: "the fine linen is the righteousness of saints" (Rev. 19:8); "he hath covered me with the robe of righteousness" (Isa. 61:10); without it, "all our righteousnesses are as filthy rags" (64:6). The text does not call him a guest; it says only "a man which had not on a wedding garment." The saints of the Tribulation are given their robes (Rev. 6:11; 7:9) and must keep them (Rev. 16:15), so the man is either an invitee of that time who did not endure to the end, whose end is the unprofitable servant's (Matt. 25:8, 30), or the adversary himself. The cross-references for the second answer are striking. The king calls him "Friend," the word the Lord spoke to Judas in the garden: "Friend, wherefore art thou come?" (26:50; cf. Ps. 55:13). Judas was "a devil" (John 6:70) and "the son of perdition" (John 17:12), the title Paul gives the man of sin of the last days (2 Thess. 2:3); Judas went "to his own place" (Acts 1:25), and the beast "was, and is not; and shall ascend out of the bottomless pit, and go into perdition" (Rev. 17:8). The sentence on the man, "Bind him hand and foot," answers to the binding at the end of the Tribulation, when the dragon is laid hold on and bound (Rev. 20:1–3). "For many are called, but few are chosen" (Matt. 22:14): many hear the call, but the garment must be taken, and only those who come to Him receive it (John 6:37).

Definition. Here the kingdom of heaven runs from the invitation of the first coming and the apostles, through the burning of Jerusalem in A.D. 70, past the church age the parable leaves unspoken, to the gathering of the guests in the Tribulation and the King's inspection of them at the marriage supper of the Lamb. Its bride is the church, its guests are the saints of the Tribulation, and the one man cast out is bound as the adversary is bound. Historically it describes Israel's refusal; doctrinally, the Tribulation and the Second Advent; devotionally, the free invitation of the gospel feast (Isa. 55:1–2; Rev. 3:20).

The door shut by the Pharisees (23:13)

"But woe unto you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! for ye shut up the kingdom of heaven against men: for ye neither go in yourselves, neither suffer ye them that are entering to go in" (23:13). The kingdom had been preached as at hand (3:2; 4:17; 10:7), and men were entering it by receiving the King and His messengers. The leaders refused John (21:25, 32), credited the King's works to Beelzebub (12:24), and blocked the way for the people who were watching them, persuading the multitude to ask for Barabbas (27:20) and putting confessors out of the synagogue (John 9:22): "Have any of the rulers or of the Pharisees believed on him?" (John 7:48). Luke records the same charge in other words: "ye have taken away the key of knowledge: ye entered not in yourselves, and them that were entering in ye hindered" (Luke 11:52). They went on doing it after the cross, "Forbidding us to speak to the Gentiles that they might be saved" (1 Thess. 2:16).

Definition. Here the kingdom of heaven is the kingdom as offered at the first coming: a door men were going through by repentance and faith in the King, which the religious leaders shut against themselves and against those who followed them. Historically the words concern the

leaders of that generation and the apostolic preaching that followed; devotionally they fall on every religious leader who keeps men from Christ by teaching them to trust their religion.

"Then": the virgins and the talents (25:1, 14)

"Then shall the kingdom of heaven be likened unto ten virgins, which took their lamps, and went forth to meet the bridegroom" (25:1). "Then" ties the parable to the time just described: the abomination of desolation (24:15), "those days" (24:22, 29), the coming of the Son of man (24:30), and the servants who must be found watching when their lord comes (24:45–51). This is the eleventh kingdom-of-heaven parable in Matthew, and it belongs to the Olivet discourse. The virgins are not the bride. The bride is one "chaste virgin" (2 Cor. 11:2); "virgins" in the plural belong to the Tribulation (Rev. 14:1–5) and follow the bride (Ps. 45:14; Song 6:8–9). They go out "to meet the bridegroom," who is returning from the wedding, like "men that wait for their lord, when he will return from the wedding" (Luke 12:36), and those who are ready go in "with him to the marriage" (Matt. 25:10). The psalm of the King's marriage has the same company: "The king's daughter . . . shall be brought unto the king in raiment of needlework: the virgins her companions that follow her shall be brought unto thee" (Ps. 45:13–14). The One who comes is "the Son of man" (Matt. 25:13), an already married Bridegroom, and nothing here is the "twinkling of an eye" in which the church is caught up (1 Cor. 15:52).

The oil is the Spirit. When Samuel anointed David with the horn of oil, "the Spirit of the LORD came upon David from that day forward" (1 Sam. 16:13); "the anointing which ye have received of him abideth in you" (1 John 2:27). All ten had lamps. The foolish "took no oil with them" (Matt. 25:3), and when the cry came at midnight they said, "our lamps are gone out" (25:8). Before Pentecost the Spirit could be withdrawn from a man: "the Spirit of the LORD departed from Saul" (1 Sam. 16:14); Samson "wist not that the LORD was departed from him"

(Judg. 16:20); David prayed, "take not thy holy spirit from me" (Ps. 51:11). The church-age believer is told the reverse: "grieve not the holy Spirit of God, whereby ye are sealed unto the day of redemption" (Eph. 4:30). The virgins of the Tribulation stand on the Old Testament side of that line, for when the body of Christ is gone the conditions of the law return, and "the man which doeth those things shall live by them" (Rom. 10:5). The counsel of the wise, "go ye rather to them that sell" (Matt. 25:9), recalls the widow's oil in 2 Kings 4:1–7, a wholly Jewish setting. In those days the saints are they "that keep the commandments of God, and the faith of Jesus" (Rev. 14:12), and "he that shall endure unto the end, the same shall be saved" (Matt. 24:13). The five whose lamps went out find the door shut and hear, "I know you not" (25:12). Historically the warning reached Israel in the first part of Acts, when the kingdom was offered again and refused; doctrinally it waits for the Tribulation; devotionally it says that not all who profess are ready.

"For the kingdom of heaven is as a man travelling into a far country, who called his own servants, and delivered unto them his goods" (25:14). Here the words "the kingdom of heaven is" stand in italics; the translators supplied them because the Greek begins "For as a man," carrying on the comparison of verse 1. The man is the Lord, who "went into a far country to receive for himself a kingdom, and to return" (Luke 19:12). "After a long time the lord of those servants cometh, and reckoneth with them" (Matt. 25:19), and the unprofitable servant, who hid his lord's talent in the earth, is cast "into outer darkness" (25:30). The whole chapter concerns the Advent of the King (25:31), not the catching up of the church, and the unprofitable servant is a worker of the Tribulation who did not "endure unto the end" (24:13). Devotionally, every servant of Christ in any age will give the same kind of account (Rom. 14:12; 1 Cor. 3:13).

Definition. In Matthew 25 the kingdom of heaven is the kingdom as it stands in the Tribulation and at its end, with its waiting virgins and its reckoned servants, immediately before the King sits "upon the throne of his glory" and the nations are gathered before Him (25:31–32). Then the King says to those on His right hand, "Come, ye blessed of my Father, inherit the kingdom prepared for you from the foundation of the world" (25:34), and the kingdom of heaven is manifested on the earth.

The kingdom of heaven at a glance

The table gathers the thirty-three uses, with what each refers to and the period it describes.

Matthew	What "the kingdom of heaven" refers to	When
3:2; 4:17; 10:7	The kingdom of the God of heaven promised through David's Son, announced as at hand and offered to Israel	John's and Christ's ministry (Luke 3:1–2); announced again before the end (10:23; 24:14)
5:3, 10	The coming kingdom, promised to the poor in spirit and the persecuted	Spoken at the first coming; possessed when the meek inherit the earth
5:19 (twice), 20	The kingdom under the King's law, with its ranks and its standard of righteousness	Spoken to Israel under the law; in force when the King reigns
7:21	The kingdom entered or refused "in that day"	The Advent at the end of the Tribulation
8:11	The kingdom in which Gentiles from east and west sit with the patriarchs	After the resurrection of the just; the Millennium
11:11	The kingdom of the prophets, whose least member stands above John in position	The kingdom to come at the Second Advent
11:12	The kingdom pressed into by sinners and grasped at by usurpers	From John's preaching to the time Jesus spoke
13:11, 24, 31, 33, 44, 45, 47, 52	The kingdom in mystery: the whole sphere of profession in the King's absence, true and false together	From the first coming to "the end of the world," the age of Christendom (cf. Rev. 2–3)
16:19	The door of faith opened by Peter's keys to the Jew and to the Gentile	Acts 2 and 10, with Samaria in Acts 8
18:1, 3, 4	The coming kingdom, entered by conversion, with its order of greatness	Spoken before the cross; doctrinally the Tribulation and Millennium
18:23	The King's dominion over His servants under the law of forgiveness	Spoken before the cross; doctrinally the Tribulation; reckoning at His return

Matthew	What "the kingdom of heaven" refers to	When
19:12	The kingdom's cause, served by forgoing marriage	Wherever the King's work is done
19:14	The kingdom made up of the childlike	Every phase of the kingdom
19:23	The kingdom entered by salvation, with its glory in "the regeneration"	Entrance now; the regeneration at the Second Advent
20:1	The kingdom in mystery: the King's labourers through the age, paid at evening	From the apostles to the last hour before the Advent
22:2	The marriage of the King's Son: Israel's refusal, the church as bride, the Tribulation's guests	From the first coming through A.D. 70, past the church age, to the marriage supper
23:13	The kingdom being entered, shut against men by the Pharisees	The first coming and the apostolic preaching
25:1, 14	The kingdom in the Tribulation, with its waiting virgins and reckoned servants	The Tribulation and the Advent of the King (25:31)

Not a Jewish national kingdom only

Read passage by passage, Matthew's phrase does not belong to one period. Only in the "at hand" verses and the two closest to them (11:12; 23:13) is the kingdom of heaven the kingdom offered to the nation of Israel as such, and even there the announcement looks ahead to the end of the age (10:23; 24:14). Everywhere else it reaches further: to the King's coming reign with Gentiles at the patriarchs' table (8:11); to the age-long mixture of true and false in which the devil sows tares, the mustard tree shelters unclean birds, and the woman leavens the meal of the whole professing body (13), following the course of the churches of Revelation 2–3; to the door of faith opened to the Gentiles (16:19); to the converts who enter by being changed, whatever their nation (18:3); to the King's labourers through the whole age (20:1); to a wedding whose bride is the church and whose guests come out of the Tribulation (22:2); and to the virgins and servants of the Tribulation (25). The phrase covers every period from John the Baptist to the Millennium, and its people include Israel, the church, and the nations. A definition that confines "the kingdom of heaven" to a Jewish national kingdom on the earth does not survive Matthew 13.

That takes nothing from Israel. The kingdom promised to David is literal and future, and Matthew says so as plainly as any book in the Bible (19:28; 25:31). It means only that "the kingdom of heaven" is Matthew's name for God's kingdom in all its stages, not the name of one stage.

The kingdom of God, passage by passage

"The kingdom of God" occurs seventy times, and its uses fall into a few groups. Every reference is listed below in its place, and the same rules apply: the context first, the Bible's own definitions for its figures, and the period in view. Where a passage has a parallel already examined under "the kingdom of heaven," the parallel is noted.

Preached and at hand in the King's ministry

"Jesus came into Galilee, preaching the gospel of the kingdom of God, And saying, The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand: repent ye, and believe the gospel" (Mark 1:14–15). This is the moment Matthew records with "the kingdom of heaven is at hand" (Matt. 4:17), after John was put in prison. Luke carries the same preaching through the whole Galilean ministry: "I must preach the kingdom of God to other cities also: for therefore am I sent" (Luke 4:43); "shewing the glad tidings of the kingdom of God" (8:1); He "spake unto them of the kingdom of God, and healed them that had need of healing" (9:11). The Twelve were sent "to preach the kingdom of God, and to heal the sick" (9:2), the same commission Matthew records with "The kingdom of heaven is at hand" (Matt. 10:7). A would-be follower was told, "go thou and preach the kingdom of God" (Luke 9:60). The seventy were to say to every city, "The kingdom of God is come nigh unto you" (10:9), and to the city that rejected them, "be ye sure of this, that the kingdom of God is come nigh unto you" (10:11). "The law and the prophets were

until John: since that time the kingdom of God is preached, and every man presseth into it" (16:16), the saying that answers to Matthew 11:12–13. Luke notes that this preaching was "in the synagogues of Galilee" (4:44), a ministry to Israel; as a door for whole peoples, the kingdom was opened to the Samaritans in Acts 8 and to the Gentiles in Acts 10.

Definition. In these ten verses (Mark 1:14, 15; Luke 4:43; 8:1; 9:2, 11, 60; 10:9, 11; 16:16) the kingdom of God is the kingdom announced and offered in the ministry of the King and His messengers at the first coming, the same kingdom Matthew calls "the kingdom of heaven" in 3:2, 4:17, and 10:7.

Come upon that generation in the King

"But if I cast out devils by the Spirit of God, then the kingdom of God is come unto you" (Matt. 12:28); "But if I with the finger of God cast out devils, no doubt the kingdom of God is come upon you" (Luke 11:20). "The finger of God" is what Pharaoh's magicians called the plague they could not copy (Exod. 8:19). The strong man's kingdom is a kingdom of unclean spirits (Luke 11:18–26), the birds that catch away the seed in the parable (8:5, 12), and Paul ties the same power to the kingdom of God among the churches: "the kingdom of God is not in word, but in power" (1 Cor. 4:20). The King's power over the devils showed that the kingdom had arrived in His person. Luke 17:20–21 belongs with these. When the Pharisees "demanded . . . when the kingdom of God should come," He answered, "The kingdom of God cometh not with observation . . . for, behold, the kingdom of God is within you," and the translators put "among you" in the margin. The kingdom they were watching for was standing in the midst of them in its King. That passage is examined in detail below.

Definition. In Matthew 12:28, Luke 11:20, and Luke 17:20 (twice) and 21, the kingdom of God is the kingdom present in the person and power of its King at the first coming, come upon that generation without the outward show it expected.

The mysteries of the kingdom of God

"Unto you it is given to know the mystery of the kingdom of God" (Mark 4:11); "Unto you it is given to know the mysteries of the kingdom of God" (Luke 8:10). These are the same words, on the same occasion, as "it is given unto you to know the mysteries of the kingdom of heaven" (Matt. 13:11), and they introduce the same sower. Mark adds a parable of his own: "So is the kingdom of God, as if a man should cast seed into the ground," and the seed springs and grows, "he knoweth not how," until "he putteth in the sickle, because the harvest is come" (Mark 4:26–29). The mustard seed is told under this name twice. In Mark: "Whereunto shall we liken the kingdom of God? . . . It is like a grain of mustard seed," which "shooteth out great branches; so that the fowls of the air may lodge under the shadow of it" (4:30–32). In Luke: "Unto what is the kingdom of God like? . . . It is like a grain of mustard seed, which a man took, and cast into his garden; and it grew, and waxed a great tree; and the fowls of the air lodged in the branches of it" (Luke 13:18–19). And Luke tells the leaven under this name: "Whereunto shall I liken the kingdom of God? It is like leaven, which a woman took and hid in three measures of meal, till the whole was leavened" (13:20–21).

Definition. The mysteries of the kingdom of God are the mysteries of the kingdom of heaven: the same sower, the same mustard tree with the same birds, the same woman, the same leaven, and the same meal. Every definition drawn from Scripture at Matthew 13 holds here, because the figures are the same figures, and so does the period, the age between the advents that ends with the harvest (Mark 4:29). Luke calls the kingdom that the woman leavens "the kingdom

of God." In Mark 4:11, 26, and 30 and Luke 8:10 and 13:18 and 20, the kingdom of God is the kingdom in its mystery form, the sphere of profession in the age of Christendom. Because Luke tells the leaven under this name, the warning reaches true believers too: false doctrine works even among the born again (1 Cor. 5:6; Gal. 5:9).

Entering the kingdom of God

The largest group concerns who enters and how. Its first appearance in Matthew already hints that more than a Jewish Messianic kingdom is in view, for it is joined at once to God's righteousness and set above food and clothing: "But seek ye first the kingdom of God, and his righteousness; and all these things shall be added unto you" (Matt. 6:33); "But rather seek ye the kingdom of God; and all these things shall be added unto you" (Luke 12:31), followed at once by "it is your Father's good pleasure to give you the kingdom" (12:32). The kingdom of God "is not meat and drink" (Rom. 14:17). It belongs to the poor: "Blessed be ye poor: for yours is the kingdom of God" (Luke 6:20), Luke's form of Matthew 5:3. The woes on the rich and the full that follow (6:24–25) show that Luke's poor are the poor in body. Its least member is greater than John (Luke 7:28; cf. Matt. 11:11). It is not for the man who turns back: "No man, having put his hand to the plough, and looking back, is fit for the kingdom of God" (Luke 9:62). It is worth an eye: "it is better for thee to enter into the kingdom of God with one eye, than having two eyes to be cast into hell fire" (Mark 9:47), where Matthew's record of the same saying has "enter into life" (Matt. 18:9). It belongs to the childlike: "Suffer the little children to come unto me, and forbid them not: for of such is the kingdom of God. Verily I say unto you, Whosoever shall not receive the kingdom of God as a little child, he shall not enter therein" (Mark 10:14–15; cf. Luke 18:16–17). Matthew has the same words with "of such is the kingdom of heaven" (Matt. 19:14) and the same condition in "Except ye be converted, and become as little children" (18:3).

It is hard for the rich: "How hardly shall they that have riches enter into the kingdom of God!" (Mark 10:23); "how hard is it for them that trust in riches to enter into the kingdom of God!" (10:24); "It is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle, than for a rich man to enter into the kingdom of God" (10:25; cf. Luke 18:24–25; Matt. 19:24). Those who leave all "for the kingdom of God's sake" receive "manifold more in this present time, and in the world to come life everlasting" (Luke 18:29–30). The scribe who answered discreetly was "not far from the kingdom of God" (Mark 12:34). "The publicans and the harlots go into the kingdom of God before you," Jesus told the chief priests and elders, because those sinners believed John (Matt. 21:31–32). And the door is the new birth: "Except a man be born again, he cannot see the kingdom of God. . . . Except a man be born of water and of the Spirit, he cannot enter into the kingdom of God" (John 3:3, 5). Nicodemus had asked how a man could be born when he is old (3:4), and Jesus set the two births side by side: "That which is born of the flesh is flesh; and that which is born of the Spirit is spirit" (3:6). The water is not a ceremony: water baptism is nowhere made the means of the new birth, and Paul's baptism into Christ names no water at all (Rom. 6:3; 1 Cor. 12:13; Gal. 3:27; Col. 2:12). The man born of God enters as a newborn babe (1 Pet. 2:2) when he receives Christ (John 1:12–13).

Definition. In these twenty-one verses (Matt. 6:33; 19:24; 21:31; Mark 9:47; 10:14, 15, 23, 24, 25; 12:34; Luke 6:20; 7:28; 9:62; 12:31; 18:16, 17, 24, 25, 29; John 3:3, 5) the kingdom of God is the kingdom men enter by the new birth, with the same conditions Matthew attaches to the kingdom of heaven: poverty of spirit, conversion like a child, and the impossibility of the rich entering apart from God. Entrance is now; possession is "in the world to come."

The kingdom taken from Israel

"Therefore say I unto you, The kingdom of God shall be taken from you, and given to a nation bringing forth the fruits thereof" (Matt. 21:43). The parable has just defined its terms: the vineyard is Israel, for "the vineyard of the LORD of hosts is the house of Israel" (Isa. 5:7); the husbandmen are her leaders; the servants are the prophets; and the son is the heir they cast out and slew (Matt. 21:33–39). What those leaders held, and were about to lose, Jesus calls "the kingdom of God." The householder is God the Father, and every detail of the parable carries its meaning. The kingdom was taken from the Jews as a nation and given to the Gentiles, as Paul said at the close of Acts: "the salvation of God is sent unto the Gentiles, and that they will hear it" (Acts 28:28). Peter calls the believers of this age "an holy nation, a peculiar people" (1 Pet. 2:9), and the natural branches stay broken off only "until the fulness of the Gentiles be come in" (Rom. 11:25–26).

Definition. In Matthew 21:43 the kingdom of God is the theocratic kingdom committed to Israel as the LORD's vineyard, taken from that generation at the first coming and given to the Gentiles, the nation that brings forth its fruits in this age, until Israel is restored.

The kingdom of God to come in power and glory

"Verily I say unto you, That there be some of them that stand here, which shall not taste of death, till they have seen the kingdom of God come with power" (Mark 9:1; cf. Luke 9:27). Six days later three of them saw it in preview on the mount, where they "were eyewitnesses of his majesty" (2 Pet. 1:16); Matthew records the promise as "the Son of man coming in his kingdom" (Matt. 16:28). The verse before it is the Second Advent (Luke 9:26), and the kingdom of God shows itself when the King comes in power. The patriarchs and prophets will be seen "in the kingdom of God," and "they shall come from the east, and from the west, and from the north,

and from the south, and shall sit down in the kingdom of God" (Luke 13:28–29), Matthew's Gentiles at Abraham's table (Matt. 8:11). After Jesus spoke of the recompense "at the resurrection of the just," a guest said, "Blessed is he that shall eat bread in the kingdom of God" (Luke 14:14–15). When the King returns He brings the kingdom with Him, and bread is eaten in it; the "great supper" that follows (14:16) is free, and the just of all ages sit at it. Near Jerusalem "they thought that the kingdom of God should immediately appear," and Jesus answered with the nobleman who went into a far country "to receive for himself a kingdom, and to return" (19:11–12). When the Son of man is seen "coming in a cloud with power and great glory," then "know ye that the kingdom of God is nigh at hand" (21:27, 31). The sign is the fig tree, self-righteous Israel, putting forth (21:29–30; cf. 13:6–9), and "all the trees" are the kingdoms around her (Dan. 4:20–22; Ezek. 17:24). At the last Passover He would not eat it again "until it be fulfilled in the kingdom of God," nor drink of the fruit of the vine "until the kingdom of God shall come" (Luke 22:16, 18); "until that day that I drink it new in the kingdom of God" (Mark 14:25), Matthew's "in my Father's kingdom" (Matt. 26:29). What is fulfilled is the Passover, for "Christ our passover is sacrificed for us" (1 Cor. 5:7). The risen Lord ate and drank with His disciples after the cross (Luke 24:41–43; Acts 10:41), and the cup waits for the day He drinks it new in His Father's kingdom. Joseph of Arimathaea "waited for the kingdom of God" (Mark 15:43; Luke 23:51), as Simeon waited "for the consolation of Israel" and others "looked for redemption in Jerusalem" (Luke 2:25, 38).

Definition. In these twelve verses (Mark 9:1; 14:25; 15:43; Luke 9:27; 13:28, 29; 14:15; 19:11; 21:31; 22:16, 18; 23:51) the kingdom of God is the visible kingdom on the earth, previewed at the transfiguration and set up when the Son of man comes in power and great glory:

the same kingdom Matthew places under the King on "the throne of his glory" (Matt. 19:28; 25:31).

The kingdom of God preached in Acts

For forty days the risen Lord spoke "of the things pertaining to the kingdom of God" (Acts 1:3), and the disciples asked whether He would "at this time restore again the kingdom to Israel" (1:6). The two belonged together, and the kingdom of God will "appear" when the King returns (Luke 19:11). In Samaria "they believed Philip preaching the things concerning the kingdom of God, and the name of Jesus Christ" (Acts 8:12). To the disciples in Lystra, Iconium, and Antioch, Jews and Greeks together (14:1), Paul and Barnabas said "that we must through much tribulation enter into the kingdom of God" (14:21–22). In the synagogue at Ephesus Paul spent three months "disputing and persuading the things concerning the kingdom of God" (19:8), and he described his whole ministry there in two ways at once: "to testify the gospel of the grace of God" and "preaching the kingdom of God" (20:24–25). At Rome he "expounded and testified the kingdom of God, persuading them concerning Jesus, both out of the law of Moses, and out of the prophets" (28:23), and the book closes with him "Preaching the kingdom of God, and teaching those things which concern the Lord Jesus Christ, with all confidence, no man forbidding him" (28:31). At the close of Acts Paul is not preaching a Jewish kingdom only; he had already written that Jew and Gentile are baptized "into one body" (1 Cor. 12:13).

Definition. In Acts 1:3; 8:12; 14:22; 19:8; 20:25; 28:23; and 28:31 the kingdom of God is the kingdom of the law and the prophets, preached after the resurrection together with the name of Jesus Christ, to Jews, Samaritans, and Gentiles, and entered "through much tribulation." The time is the apostolic age.

The kingdom of God in the epistles

Paul uses the phrase eight times. Twice he describes the kingdom's present character: "For the kingdom of God is not meat and drink; but righteousness, and peace, and joy in the Holy Ghost" (Rom. 14:17); "For the kingdom of God is not in word, but in power" (1 Cor. 4:20). Four times it is an inheritance still to come, and in each of the four the original has the phrase without the article, "God's kingdom," as the object of "inherit": "the unrighteous shall not inherit the kingdom of God" (1 Cor. 6:9; cf. 6:10); "flesh and blood cannot inherit the kingdom of God" (15:50); "they which do such things shall not inherit the kingdom of God" (Gal. 5:21). Paul is writing to the saved, so the inheritance is not the new birth but the inheritance received as a reward: "of the Lord ye shall receive the reward of the inheritance" (Col. 3:24; cf. Eph. 5:5–7). In 1 Corinthians the unrighteous are named as persons, the lost who were never born into the kingdom ("such were some of you," 6:11); in Galatians the works of the flesh are named as deeds, which even a believer may do, and the one who does them forfeits the inheritance (Gal. 5:19–21). It is the kingdom as it appears when Christ returns (Matt. 25:31–34; Luke 19:11–27), and it is inherited in a body of flesh and bones, not flesh and blood (Luke 24:39). Once it is the cause of the work: Paul's companions of the circumcision, the only ones who stood with him in prison, are "my fellowworkers unto the kingdom of God" (Col. 4:11), and their sufferings were part of the "much tribulation" through which believers enter the kingdom (Acts 14:22). And once it is the reward of suffering, "that ye may be counted worthy of the kingdom of God, for which ye also suffer," vindicated "when the Lord Jesus shall be revealed from heaven with his mighty angels" (2 Thess. 1:5, 7). Alongside these stand the related names: God "hath translated us into the kingdom of his dear Son" (Col. 1:13); the immoral have no "inheritance in the kingdom of Christ and of God" (Eph. 5:5); the Lord "will preserve me unto his heavenly kingdom" (2 Tim.

4:18); there is "the everlasting kingdom of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ" (2 Pet. 1:11); and at the end, "Now is come salvation, and strength, and the kingdom of our God" (Rev. 12:10).

Definition. In the epistles the kingdom of God is the present character of God's rule among His people (Rom. 14:17; 1 Cor. 4:20), the cause the apostles laboured for (Col. 4:11), and the inheritance to come at Christ's appearing (1 Cor. 6:9, 10; 15:50; Gal. 5:21; 2 Thess. 1:5). The time is the present age and the coming of the Lord.

The kingdom of God at a glance

The table gathers the seventy uses by group.

Use	References	What "the kingdom of God" refers to	When
Preached and at hand	Mark 1:14, 15; Luke 4:43; 8:1; 9:2, 11, 60; 10:9, 11; 16:16	The promised kingdom announced and offered in the King's ministry	The first coming
Come in the King	Matt. 12:28; Luke 11:20; 17:20 (twice), 21	The kingdom present in the King and His power over devils	The first coming
Mysteries	Mark 4:11, 26, 30; Luke 8:10; 13:18, 20	The kingdom in mystery, told with the same sower, mustard tree, birds, woman, and leaven as Matthew 13	From the first coming to the harvest
Entrance	Matt. 6:33; 19:24; 21:31; Mark 9:47; 10:14, 15, 23, 24, 25; 12:34; Luke 6:20; 7:28; 9:62; 12:31; 18:16, 17, 24, 25, 29; John 3:3, 5	The kingdom entered by the new birth and sought first	Entrance now; possession in the world to come
Taken from Israel	Matt. 21:43	The theocratic kingdom committed to Israel, taken and given to the Gentiles	Taken at the first coming
Power and glory	Mark 9:1; 14:25; 15:43; Luke 9:27; 13:28, 29; 14:15; 19:11; 21:31; 22:16, 18; 23:51	The visible kingdom on the earth	Previewed at the transfiguration; set up at the Second Advent (the Passover of Luke 22:16 fulfilled at the cross)
Acts	Acts 1:3; 8:12; 14:22; 19:8; 20:25; 28:23, 31	The kingdom of the law and the prophets, preached with the name of Jesus Christ	The apostolic age
Epistles	Rom. 14:17; 1 Cor. 4:20; 6:9, 10; 15:50; Gal. 5:21; Col. 4:11; 2 Thess. 1:5	The present character of God's rule and the inheritance to come	The present age and Christ's appearing

What the two surveys show

Set side by side, the two surveys answer the question the words alone left open. Neither phrase is tied to one period or one people. "The kingdom of heaven" is used for the kingdom offered to Israel, the coming reign with Gentiles at the table, the mystery form of Christendom with its tares and leaven, the door of faith opened to Jew and Gentile, the work of the whole age, the Tribulation, and the kingdom manifested in glory. "The kingdom of God" is used for the same offer, the same mysteries told with the same figures, the same conditions of entrance, the same future banquet and glory, and, in Acts and the epistles, for the kingdom preached, displayed in the character of God's people, and still to be inherited. What tells the reader which phase is in view is never the phrase; it is the context: who is speaking, to whom, and about what time. That is the finding the rest of this paper tests against the first mentions, the Old Testament, the parallel records, and the arguments for keeping the two phrases apart.

First mentions and the meaning of "heaven"

First mentions

The first time God's kingdom is named as His is in the story of David and Solomon: "he hath chosen Solomon my son to sit upon the throne of the kingdom of the LORD over Israel" (1 Chron. 28:5). The first mention of "the kingdom of the LORD," that is, the kingdom of God by another name, is a literal throne in Jerusalem occupied by a literal king over a literal nation.

In the New Testament, "kingdom of heaven" is first heard from John the Baptist in the wilderness of Judaea: "Repent ye: for the kingdom of heaven is at hand" (Matt. 3:2). Nothing is defined; the phrase is announced to an audience expected to know what it means. "Kingdom of God" first appears on Jesus' lips in the Sermon on the Mount: "But seek ye first the kingdom of God, and his righteousness" (Matt. 6:33). Ruckman himself calls attention to this first mention

and to its pairing with righteousness.[4] He is right to notice it. But he does not notice that the same Sermon had already tied righteousness to the *other* phrase: "except your righteousness shall exceed the righteousness of the scribes and Pharisees, ye shall in no case enter into the kingdom of heaven" (5:20). In its first chapter of use, the kingdom of heaven is already a kingdom that righteousness enters.

"Heaven" as a name for God's rule

The strongest single plank in the two-kingdom argument is a plain one: God is not heaven, and heaven is not God. Ruckman gives twelve reasons, beginning with "Birds fly in heaven; they do not fly in God" and ending with "The words 'GOD' and 'HEAVEN' are spelled with different letters!"[5] Every one of the twelve is true of the created heavens. Birds do fly in the sky. But the question is not whether the sky is God. The question is whether the Bible ever uses the word "heaven" to stand for the God who rules from heaven, so that "the kingdom of heaven" could mean "the kingdom of the One who reigns there." That question is answered by the Bible itself, and answered in the very book from which Matthew draws his phrase.

Daniel told Nebuchadnezzar that he would be driven from men "till thou know that the most High ruleth in the kingdom of men, and giveth it to whomsoever he will" (Dan. 4:25). In the next verse the same truth is restated: "thy kingdom shall be sure unto thee, after that thou shalt have known that the heavens do rule" (4:26). In verse 25 "the most High ruleth"; in verse 26 "the heavens do rule." The heavens do not rule; God does. Yet the Holy Ghost, through Daniel, says "the heavens do rule" and means "the most High ruleth." That is the Bible defining its own idiom, in a chapter about the kingdom, two verses apart. The same idiom stands behind

[4]Ruckman, *Book of Matthew*, on Matt. 6:33.

[5]Ruckman, *Sure Word of Prophecy*, chap. 4.

Daniel 2:44, where "the God of heaven" sets up the kingdom, and Daniel 7:27, where "the kingdom under the whole heaven" is given to the saints.

The New Testament uses the idiom in the same way. The prodigal son says, "Father, I have sinned against heaven, and before thee" (Luke 15:18, 21). He had not sinned against the sky. Jesus asks the priests, "The baptism of John, whence was it? from heaven, or of men?" (Matt. 21:25); "from heaven" means "from God," as their fear of answering shows. John the Baptist says, "A man can receive nothing, except it be given him from heaven" (John 3:27). In every case "heaven" names the authority of God without naming God. Bullinger identifies the figure precisely: metonymy (*a figure of speech in which a thing or concept is referred to by the name of something closely associated with it, rather than by its own name*) of the subject, in which "heaven" is "frequently used . . . for God Himself, Whose dwelling is there," and he lists Daniel 4:26, Matthew 21:25, and Luke 15:21 among his examples.[6] Ironside wrote in the margin of his own Bible at Matthew 3:2: "'Kingdom of Heaven' is a dispensational aspect of the Kingdom of God—'the reign of the heavens' upon earth. It is a term used only in Matthew and connects with Daniel 4, 'the heavens do rule.'"[7] Edersheim reports that in the Jewish writings of the period "the word 'heaven' was very often used instead of 'God,' so as to avoid unduly familiarising the ear with the Sacred Name," and that the terms "Kingdom of heaven" and "Kingdom of God" were treated as equivalent.[8]

So "things different are not equal" is a sound rule, but it is being applied to the wrong things. The sky and God are different and are not equal. "Heaven" as a figure for God's rule and

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[6]E. W. Bullinger, *The Companion Bible* (London: Oxford University Press, 1909–1922), Appendix 114.

[7]H. A. Ironside, *Dr. Ironside's Bible: Notes and Quotes from the Margins* (Neptune, NJ: Loizeaux Brothers, 1955), 134 (note on Matt. 3:2).

[8]Alfred Edersheim, *The Life and Times of Jesus the Messiah*, 2 vols. (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1953), 1:267 (bk. 2, chap. 11).

"God" are two ways of naming one ruler, and the Bible uses them side by side. If Daniel 4:25–26 does not prove that, nothing using Biblical language alone can.

That said, the Jewish reverence for the Name does not by itself explain Matthew. Matthew uses the word "God" freely, more than fifty times, and uses "kingdom of God" five times. Something more is going on, and it belongs to the whole design of his Gospel. Matthew, above all the gospel writers, sets heaven and earth in relation. He speaks of "your Father which is in heaven," "your heavenly Father," and the like in some twenty verses; Mark has such an expression in two adjacent verses (11:25–26) and Luke in two (11:2, 13). He gives the petition "Thy kingdom come. Thy will be done in earth, as it is in heaven" (6:10), where Luke has the shorter "as in heaven, so in earth" (Luke 11:2). He alone records "Whatsoever thou shalt bind on earth shall be bound in heaven" (16:19; cf. 18:18), and he closes with "All power is given unto me in heaven and in earth" (28:18). "The kingdom of the heavens," in that Gospel, is heaven's rule reaching the earth: the very kingdom "the God of heaven" promised to "set up" in the days of the fourth Gentile empire (Dan. 2:44), covenanted to David's seed, and now announced as "at hand" because David's Son had come. Scofield saw this clearly: the phrase "is called the kingdom of the heavens because it is the rule of the heavens over the earth."[9] On this point the two-kingdom teachers are right, and the paper will say so again: in Matthew, the kingdom of heaven is heaven's rule over the earth through David's Son, the kingdom promised to Israel, followed through every stage from the offer to the throne of glory and opened to Gentiles as well as Jews. The error lies in the next step, which concludes that the *other* phrase must therefore name something that is not earthly.

[9]C. I. Scofield, ed., *The Scofield Reference Bible* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1917), note on Matt. 3:2, 996.

The Old Testament foundation: whose kingdom was Israel's?

Because neither phrase occurs in the Old Testament, a student who wants to know what the Old Testament calls the literal kingdom over Israel has to read what it actually says. What it says is decisive.

When David charged the princes concerning his son, he said, "he hath chosen Solomon my son to sit upon the throne of the kingdom of the LORD over Israel" (1 Chron. 28:5). When Solomon was crowned, "Solomon sat on the throne of the LORD as king instead of David his father" (29:23). When Abijah rebuked Jeroboam's army, he said, "ye think to withstand the kingdom of the LORD in the hand of the sons of David" (2 Chron. 13:8). God's own word to David through Nathan was, "I will settle him in mine house and in my kingdom for ever" (1 Chron. 17:14). Four times, in the plainest historical style, the physical, political, Davidic throne in Jerusalem is called the LORD's kingdom. It had a capital, an army, a tax roll, and golden calves on its border. It was God's kingdom.

This is not a late idea. From the beginning the nation was a theocracy in the strict sense. When Israel asked Samuel for a king, the LORD said, "they have not rejected thee, but they have rejected me, that I should not reign over them" (1 Sam. 8:7). The throne of David was a delegated throne; the real King was the LORD, and the son of David sat "on the throne of the LORD." That is why the promise to David was a promise about God's kingdom: "thine house and thy kingdom shall be established for ever before thee: thy throne shall be established for ever" (2 Sam. 7:16), and, in the parallel, "in my kingdom for ever" (1 Chron. 17:14). Isaiah's prophecy of the child born places the government "upon the throne of David, and upon his kingdom" (Isa. 9:7). Ezekiel's promise of restoration ends with "David my servant shall be king

over them" (Ezek. 37:24). Zechariah's ends with "the LORD shall be king over all the earth" (Zech. 14:9). The Davidic kingdom and the LORD's kingship over the earth are one subject.

Alongside this, the Old Testament also speaks of God's rule over everything, always, whether men acknowledge it or not: "The LORD hath prepared his throne in the heavens; and his kingdom ruleth over all" (Ps. 103:19); "Thy kingdom is an everlasting kingdom, and thy dominion endureth throughout all generations" (Ps. 145:13); "his kingdom is from generation to generation" (Dan. 4:34). Here "kingdom" means reign rather than realm, and the reign is universal.

Two conclusions follow for the question at hand. First, although the Old Testament never uses the exact phrase "kingdom of God," it gives no support whatever to the claim that God's kingdom is by nature non-physical. The only kingdom it ever calls God's, apart from His universal rule, is the literal throne over Israel. Second, Ruckman's statement that "there is NO Kingdom of 'God' from Adam to Christ"[10] cannot be squared with 1 Chronicles 28:5, 2 Chronicles 13:8, Psalm 103:19, or Daniel 4:34. The Old Testament says the opposite in so many words, and Jesus confirms it when He places "Abraham, and Isaac, and Jacob, and all the prophets, in the kingdom of God" (Luke 13:28).

The promised kingdom was always both literal and spiritual

One more Old Testament observation has to be made before turning to the Gospels, because it bears directly on the question of what Jesus offered. The prophets never promised Israel a physical kingdom *as opposed to* a spiritual one, or a spiritual renewal *instead of* a national restoration. In every major kingdom promise the two are one promise.

[10]Ruckman, *Sure Word of Prophecy*, chap. 7, "Postponement."

Moses foretold that Israel, scattered "among all the nations," would be gathered and brought "into the land which thy fathers possessed," and in the same breath that "the LORD thy God will circumcise thine heart, and the heart of thy seed, to love the LORD thy God with all thine heart" (Deut. 30:1–6). Jeremiah's new covenant puts God's law "in their inward parts" and writes it "in their hearts" (Jer. 31:33), and the same oracle guarantees the nation's permanence as long as the sun and moon endure and describes the rebuilding of Jerusalem landmark by landmark (31:35–40). Ezekiel is the clearest of all: "I will take you from among the heathen, and gather you out of all countries, and will bring you into your own land. Then will I sprinkle clean water upon you . . . A new heart also will I give you, and a new spirit will I put within you . . . And I will put my spirit within you . . . And ye shall dwell in the land that I gave to your fathers" (Ezek. 36:24–28). Land, cleansing, new heart, indwelling Spirit, land again: one promise, in one paragraph, with no seam. Zechariah joins the mourning for the pierced One and the fountain for sin (12:10–13:1) to the day when "the LORD shall be king over all the earth" (14:9).

This means that the question "Did Jesus offer Israel a physical kingdom or a spiritual one?" is badly formed. The kingdom the prophets promised was a literal reign of David's Son over a regenerated nation in its own land. It had a throne and it had a new heart. To enter it a man had to repent, and when he did he would eat and drink in it. Any account of the Gospels that sets the two against each other has already departed from the prophets Jesus came to fulfill.

Comparing Scripture with Scripture: the parallel sayings

The Holy Ghost gave the church four Gospels, and three of them record many of the same sayings of Jesus from the same occasions. This is the most direct evidence available for what the two phrases mean, because it lets the Bible interpret the Bible. The test is simple. If, when Matthew writes "kingdom of heaven" and Mark or Luke writes "kingdom of God," they

are reporting *the same words spoken at the same moment*, then the two phrases are reporting the same thing. The following are the principal cases.

Saying	Matthew ("kingdom of heaven")	Mark or Luke ("kingdom of God")	Same occasion?
Jesus' opening proclamation after John's imprisonment	4:12, 17: "Repent: for the kingdom of heaven is at hand"	Mark 1:14–15: "The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand: repent ye"	Yes
The first beatitude	5:3: "theirs is the kingdom of heaven"	Luke 6:20: "yours is the kingdom of God"	Parallel sermons
The charge to the Twelve	10:7: "preach, saying, The kingdom of heaven is at hand"	Luke 9:2: "he sent them to preach the kingdom of God"	Yes
The least in the kingdom greater than John	11:11	Luke 7:28	Yes
The kingdom and violence	11:12: "the kingdom of heaven suffereth violence"	Luke 16:16: "every man presseth into it" (the same Greek verb)	Related saying, different setting
The purpose of parables	13:11: "the mysteries of the kingdom of heaven"	Mark 4:11; Luke 8:10: "the mystery [mysteries] of the kingdom of God"	Yes, same discourse
The mustard seed	13:31	Mark 4:30–31; Luke 13:18–19	Mark yes; Luke a later telling
The leaven	13:33	Luke 13:20–21	Same parable, later telling
Some shall not taste of death	16:28: "till they see the Son of man coming in his kingdom"	Mark 9:1: "till they have seen the kingdom of God come with power"; Luke 9:27	Yes
Become as little children	18:3	Mark 10:15; Luke 18:17	Same teaching, different setting
"Of such is the kingdom"	19:14	Mark 10:14; Luke 18:16	Yes
The rich man and the needle's eye	19:23–24 (both phrases)	Mark 10:23–25; Luke 18:24–25	Yes
Sitting down with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob	8:11–12	Luke 13:28–29	Related saying, different setting
Drinking the fruit of the vine new	26:29: "in my Father's kingdom"	Mark 14:25; Luke 22:16, 18: "in the kingdom of God"	Yes, the Last Supper

The last column matters, because the argument does not rest on every row equally. Matthew 8:11 and Luke 13:28–29, and Matthew 11:12 and Luke 16:16, are related sayings from different settings; they show that Jesus taught the same things under both names, but they are not

verbatim reports of one moment. The rows marked "Yes" are. They are the same event. Matthew 4:17 and Mark 1:14–15 are both explicitly dated to the moment John was put in prison. Matthew 13:11, Mark 4:11, and Luke 8:10 are the same private answer to the same question about why Jesus spoke in parables, in the same discourse by the sea. Matthew 19:14, Mark 10:14, and Luke 18:16 are the same rebuke on the same occasion when children were brought to Him. Matthew 16:28, Mark 9:1, and Luke 9:27 are the same promise, six days before the transfiguration, which fulfilled it. Matthew 26:29, Mark 14:25, and Luke 22:18 are the same words at the same table on the same night.

The case that settles the matter, though, is inside Matthew alone. After the rich young ruler went away, "Then said Jesus unto his disciples, Verily I say unto you, That a rich man shall hardly enter into the kingdom of heaven. And again I say unto you, It is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle, than for a rich man to enter into the kingdom of God" (Matt. 19:23–24). One speaker, one audience, one subject, one man just departed, and the second sentence introduced with "And again I say unto you," which in ordinary speech and in Matthew's usage marks a restatement of the same point with greater force. Mark records both sentences of the same conversation and uses "kingdom of God" in both (Mark 10:23–25). The disciples then ask, "Who then can be saved?" They heard one warning about one entrance, and so did Mark. It is worth recording that Ruckman's commentary on Matthew prints both verses and discusses the camel and the rich man without offering any explanation of the change of name between them.[11]

Ruckman's rule was that two different things are never identical "unless there is a deliberate definition given, equating two things to be identical in the word of God."[12] That is a fair demand, and the parallel records meet it. When the Spirit of God causes three men to write

[11]Ruckman, *Book of Matthew*, on Matt. 19:23–24.

[12]Ruckman, *Sure Word of Prophecy*, chap. 4.

down the same sentence spoken at the same moment, and one writes "heaven" where the others write "God," the Spirit has defined the terms as equivalent more deliberately than any "this is" could. Comparing Scripture with Scripture is not one method among several here; it is the only method the Bible itself authorizes, and it gives one answer.

This does not make the two phrases empty variations. "Heaven" stresses where the kingdom comes from and its rule over the earth; "God" stresses whose kingdom it is. Matthew's Jewish readers heard in "the kingdom of the heavens" the kingdom of Daniel 2 and 7, coming down to replace the Gentile kingdoms; Mark's and Luke's readers heard the same kingdom named by its King. It is the same relation that holds between "Son of man" and "Son of God": two titles, different emphases, one Person. Nobody argues that because "man" and "God" are different words, spelled with different letters, there must be two Christs.

The two-kingdom position stated fairly

Before the proof texts on each side are tested, the position under review should be set out as its own advocates state it, with its qualifications, because it is more developed than the slogan "kingdom of God is spiritual, kingdom of heaven is physical" suggests.

Ruckman's book begins the definition not in the Gospels but in Genesis 1:1. "In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth." God, he argues, is King over two domains. "He is King over the Kingdom of HEAVEN, for 'In the beginning God created the HEAVEN. . . .' He is King over the Kingdom of God, for as a Spirit, everything SPIRITUAL (past, present, and future) would be under Him. . . . He, therefore, has two crowns; the name of one of them is 'THE KINGDOM OF GOD,' and the name of the other is 'THE KINGDOM OF HEAVEN.'"[13] The kingdom of heaven "is that literal and physical, visible domain, of which the earth was chosen to

[13]Ruckman, *Sure Word of Prophecy*, chap. 4.

be the 'capitol.' It is a kingdom that includes the comets, meteors, meteorites, moons, planets, stars, and the spaces between them; it can be clearly seen with the naked eye."[14] It "is always an earthly, literal, visible, physical" kingdom.[15] The kingdom of God is the domain of spirit beings and, after Calvary, of regenerated men: "the Kingdom of GOD, in this age, is composed of born-again children of God."[16]

Both crowns were given to Adam and separated at the fall: "One goes back to God who gave it—this is the Kingdom of God. One remains on earth in the possession of 'the god of this world.'"[17] Israel under David's house held the crown of the kingdom of heaven until Jeconiah; "there is NO Kingdom of 'God' from Adam to Christ, and there is NO Kingdom of 'Heaven' from Jeconiah to John the Baptist."[18] After the temptation "Jesus comes down from the mount with TWO glittering crowns intact"; Matthew 5–7 is the constitution of the kingdom of heaven "given now openly to Israel"; in Matthew 12 the leaders "officially reject the King"; in Matthew 13 the kingdom of heaven "is going to assume a 'mystery' form"; and at the cross "The Kingdom of HEAVEN disappears from the face of the earth, and the Kingdom of GOD takes its place," so that "in its present 'mystery form' it is the Kingdom of GOD, not the Kingdom of HEAVEN."[19] Both kingdoms return together at the Second Advent.

Two features of the argument need to be noticed because they will matter in the evaluation. The first is that Ruckman knows the parallel passages exist and has an explanation for them. In his commentary on Luke he says, "They are not the same, but when the King is here,

[14]Ruckman, *Sure Word of Prophecy*, chap. 4.

[15]Ruckman, *Sure Word of Prophecy*, chap. 5, "Disintegration."

[16]Ruckman, *Sure Word of Prophecy*, chap. 7.

[17]Ruckman, *Sure Word of Prophecy*, chap. 4.

[18]Ruckman, *Sure Word of Prophecy*, chap. 7.

[19]Ruckman, *Sure Word of Prophecy*, chap. 7.

they are both present at the same time. That's why you will read similar statements about both in the Gospels. Dogs and cats both have four legs, they both have tails, and they both have fur. But they are not the same."[20] Others who teach the position say the same thing in other words: the phrases are used interchangeably in a few places only because both kingdoms were present in the first Adam and in the second Adam, and the man who is King over both was on the earth. This is a real argument and it will be answered as one.

The second feature is a matter of method, and it is stated by the author himself. Ruckman advises the reader *against* the comparison of passages: "it will be useless to go to the concordance and run the passages in the New Testament, where the two kingdoms SEEM similar, yet differ in many places. Such an exhaustive study would wear everyone out and leave the whole matter in as much confusion as if they had just left the Bible alone and gone out and shot eighteen holes. . . . go, instead, to the BEGINNING where God begins."[21] Of the Genesis stage of his scheme he adds, "At no time does the Gospel account of the Kingdom have to be consulted—directly or indirectly."[22] In other words, the definitions of the two phrases are fixed from passages in which neither phrase occurs, and the passages in which the phrases do occur are then read in the light of those definitions. That is precisely the order the rules of Bible study forbid. The words are the key, and the words are in the Gospels. A definition of "the kingdom of heaven" built from Genesis 1:1, Job 38, and Isaiah 14, none of which contain the expression, is a theological construction. It may be a good one or a bad one, but it cannot be what the phrase *means*, because meaning is fixed by use.

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[20]Peter S. Ruckman, *The Book of Luke*, Bible Believer's Commentary Series (Pensacola, FL: Bible Baptist Bookstore, 2013), e-book, chap. 6, on Luke 6:20.

[21]Ruckman, *Sure Word of Prophecy*, chap. 4.

[22]Ruckman, *Sure Word of Prophecy*, chap. 4.

Testing the proof texts for "the kingdom of God is always spiritual"

Those who teach that the kingdom of God is always spiritual build the definition from a small set of passages: Romans 14:17, Luke 17:20–21, 1 Corinthians 4:20, and 1 Corinthians 15:50 are the usual four, with John 3:3–5 and the new-creation texts (2 Cor. 5:17; Gal. 6:15; Titus 3:5) sometimes added. Each must be read in its own context.

Luke 17:20–21

> "And when he was demanded of the Pharisees, when the kingdom of God should come, he answered them and said, The kingdom of God cometh not with observation: Neither shall they say, Lo here! or, lo there! for, behold, the kingdom of God is within you."

The first thing to establish is who is being addressed. Jesus is answering the Pharisees, the men who a few chapters earlier had attributed His miracles to Beelzebub and whom He would shortly denounce as hypocrites. Whatever "within you" means, it cannot mean that the Holy Ghost was reigning in the hearts of those Pharisees. The common paraphrase, that when a man is saved the Holy Spirit comes to live inside him and that is why the kingdom is "within you," is a true statement about a Christian, but it is not what the verse says to the men it was said to.

The second thing is the word "within." Jesus is speaking to a group, and "within you" said to a group can mean "inside each of you" or "inside your company, in your midst." The translators knew both possibilities and put the second in the margin of the 1611 edition: "Or, among you." They also noted at verse 20 that "observation" could be rendered "outward shew."[23] The Greek word (ἐντός) occurs only once more in the New Testament, in Matthew 23:26, "cleanse first that which is within the cup," and settles nothing by itself. The translators' own

[23] *The Holy Bible* (London: Robert Barker, 1611), marginal notes at Luke 17:20 and 17:21.

margin shows that the men who gave us "within you" did not regard the verse as a settled statement that the kingdom is located inside individuals.

The third thing is the context on both sides. Earlier in the same Gospel, Jesus had told the same class of critics, "if I with the finger of God cast out devils, no doubt the kingdom of God is come upon you" (Luke 11:20). The kingdom had come upon the Pharisees' generation in the person and power of the King who was standing in front of them, and it had come without the outward show they were watching for. Immediately after this, in the same conversation, Jesus turns to the disciples and describes the kingdom's coming in the most visible terms in the Gospels: "as the lightning, that lighteneth out of the one part under heaven, shineth unto the other part under heaven; so shall also the Son of man be in his day" (17:24). So Luke 17 teaches two things at once: the kingdom does not come by watching for signs, because the King was already among them; and the Son of man will come in a day as visible as lightning. Either way, verse 21 is a word to unbelieving Pharisees about the presence of the King, not a definition of the kingdom of God for all Scripture.

None of this denies that the kingdom of God has a present, inward reality in believers. It does. But that truth rests on plainer texts (Rom. 14:17; Col. 1:13), and Luke 17:21 should not be made to carry more than it says.

Romans 14:17

> "For the kingdom of God is not meat and drink; but righteousness, and peace, and joy in the Holy Ghost."

The usual reasoning is that meat and drink are physical things, righteousness, peace, and joy are spiritual things, and therefore the kingdom of God is spiritual and not physical. But Paul is not defining the kingdom's substance; he is settling a quarrel. Romans 14 is about Christians who eat meat and Christians who eat herbs, who keep days and who do not, and who are judging

one another over it. Paul's point is that God's rule in His people does not consist in dietary scruples but in righteousness, peace, and joy. Thayer paraphrases: "the essence of the kingdom of God is not to be found in questions about eating and drinking."[24] That is exactly right, and it is a true description of the kingdom's *character*. It cannot be a statement that the kingdom of God excludes bodily eating and drinking, because Jesus said, "I will not any more eat thereof, until it be fulfilled in the kingdom of God," and, "I will not drink of the fruit of the vine, until the kingdom of God shall come" (Luke 22:16, 18), and promised the Twelve that they would "eat and drink at my table in my kingdom" (22:30). A guest at that table said, "Blessed is he that shall eat bread in the kingdom of God" (Luke 14:15), and Jesus answered with a parable of a supper, not a correction. The consistency of Scripture requires both statements to stand: the kingdom of God is not *about* meat and drink, and there will be meat and drink in it.

1 Corinthians 4:20

"For the kingdom of God is not in word, but in power." The contrast is between talk and power, not between spirit and matter. Paul is warning the puffed-up Corinthians that when he comes he will test "not the speech of them which are puffed up, but the power" (4:19). Nothing in the verse touches the question of whether the kingdom is physical.

1 Corinthians 15:50

> "Now this I say, brethren, that flesh and blood cannot inherit the kingdom of God; neither doth corruption inherit incorruption."

The verse is read to say that flesh and blood, being physical, cannot inherit the kingdom of God because that kingdom is spiritual; Ruckman uses it to exactly that end.[25] But the verse itself supplies its own parallel: "neither doth corruption inherit incorruption." Flesh and blood is

[24]Thayer, *Greek-English Lexicon*, s.v. βασιλεία.

[25]Ruckman, *Sure Word of Prophecy*, chap. 7.

set beside corruption, and the kingdom beside incorruption. What cannot inherit is *mortal, corruptible* flesh. Paul's next words are the remedy: "we shall all be changed . . . this corruptible must put on incorruption, and this mortal must put on immortality" (15:51–53). The kingdom of God is inherited by people in resurrection bodies. And a resurrection body is a body. The risen Christ said, "a spirit hath not flesh and bones, as ye see me have," and ate broiled fish and honeycomb before them (Luke 24:39–43). Paul calls the raised body "a spiritual body" (1 Cor. 15:44), and in doing so proves that "spiritual" in his vocabulary does not mean "immaterial." So 1 Corinthians 15:50 does not show that the kingdom of God is non-physical; it shows that the kingdom of God is something people enter *bodily*, in glorified bodies, at the resurrection. That is a strange proof text for the claim that the kingdom of God is never visible.

John 3:3–5

> "Except a man be born again, he cannot see the kingdom of God. . . . Except a man be born of water and of the Spirit, he cannot enter into the kingdom of God."

The new birth is the entrance requirement for the kingdom of God; that is agreed on all sides. The question is whether that requirement marks the kingdom of God off from the literal kingdom promised to Israel. Jesus' rebuke of Nicodemus answers it: "Art thou a master of Israel, and knowest not these things?" (3:10). A teacher of Israel should have known these things from his own Scriptures, and the Scripture that says them is Ezekiel 36:25–27: "Then will I sprinkle clean water upon you . . . A new heart also will I give you, and a new spirit will I put within you . . . And I will put my spirit within you." Water and Spirit, exactly as Jesus said. And that promise, as was shown above, is fastened at both ends to the land: "will bring you into your own land" (36:24); "ye shall dwell in the land that I gave to your fathers" (36:28). The new birth is not the mark of a spiritual kingdom set over against Israel's literal one. It is the entrance requirement, announced by the prophets, *for* Israel's literal kingdom, which is why Jesus lays the very same

requirement on the kingdom of heaven: "Except ye be converted, and become as little children, ye shall not enter into the kingdom of heaven" (Matt. 18:3).

John 18:36

> "My kingdom is not of this world: if my kingdom were of this world, then would my servants fight, that I should not be delivered to the Jews: but now is my kingdom not from hence."

This verse is often quoted as though Jesus had said "My kingdom is not in this world." He said it is not *of* this world, that it does not derive its authority and its methods from the world system, which is why His servants did not fight; the closing clause makes the point exact, "but now is my kingdom not from hence," and "of" and "from" say the same thing twice. The word "now" would be idle if the kingdom were by nature never to be on the earth. Jesus is telling Pilate that at present His kingdom does not draw its power from this world's sources; He is not telling him that it will never be established on this world's soil. Pilate understood Him to be claiming a kingship (18:37), and the title on the cross recorded the claim.

Testing the claim that "the kingdom of heaven is always physical"

The other half of the definition fares no better when Matthew is allowed to speak for himself.

The mystery form is called the kingdom of heaven

Ruckman holds that when the King was rejected, "the Kingdom of HEAVEN disappears from the face of the earth," and that "in its present 'mystery form' it is the Kingdom of GOD, not the Kingdom of HEAVEN."[26] But Matthew records Jesus' own name for the present stage: "it is given unto you to know the mysteries of the kingdom of heaven" (Matt. 13:11). The parables that

[26]Ruckman, *Sure Word of Prophecy*, chap. 7.

follow describe the age between the sowing and "the end of the world" (13:39–40), and in the first of them the seed is "the word of the kingdom," sown "in his heart" (13:19). Whatever the kingdom of heaven is in Matthew 13, it is something that exists in mystery form during the King's absence, is received or rejected in the heart, and awaits the harvest. That is not David's throne in Jerusalem, and it is not confined to Israel; as the survey of Matthew 13 showed, it is the whole sphere in which the King's name is professed during His absence, with the devil's tares and the woman's leaven inside it until the harvest. Ruckman's own commentary on Matthew concedes as much: in this age, he writes, "the Kingdom of Heaven is in a mystery form (see Matt. 13)."[27] The text, then, says the mystery form belongs to the kingdom of *heaven*. His scheme requires the opposite.

The kingdom of heaven is entered inwardly and was being entered then

The Sermon on the Mount opens, "Blessed are the poor in spirit: for theirs is the kingdom of heaven" (Matt. 5:3), in the present tense, to people whose qualification is a condition of spirit. "Except your righteousness shall exceed the righteousness of the scribes and Pharisees, ye shall in no case enter into the kingdom of heaven" (5:20). "Not every one that saith unto me, Lord, Lord, shall enter into the kingdom of heaven; but he that doeth the will of my Father which is in heaven" (7:21). "Except ye be converted, and become as little children, ye shall not enter into the kingdom of heaven" (18:3). And most tellingly, to the scribes and Pharisees: "ye shut up the kingdom of heaven against men: for ye neither go in yourselves, neither suffer ye them that are entering to go in" (23:13). Men were "entering" the kingdom of heaven during Jesus' ministry, before any throne was set up, and were being hindered by the religious leaders. Entrance required conversion, righteousness, and doing the Father's will. A definition that says the

[27]Ruckman, *Book of Matthew*, on Matt. 20:1–7.

kingdom of heaven is "always" an outward, visible, political domain has to explain how people were walking into it in Matthew 23.

Ruckman's concession at Matthew 21

The parable of the two sons ends, "the publicans and the harlots go into the kingdom of God before you" (Matt. 21:31); the parable of the vineyard ends, "The kingdom of God shall be taken from you, and given to a nation bringing forth the fruits thereof" (21:43). On the first, Ruckman's commentary says: "Notice that it is here the spiritual kingdom which is to appear at the Second Advent (see Luke 19:11)." On the second: "the vineyard represents Israel's earthly inheritance in the kingdom of God, which comes on earth visibly at the return of the Lord."[28] Those are honest readings of the verses, and they are fatal to the definition. A kingdom of God that "comes on earth visibly at the return of the Lord," and in which Israel has an "earthly inheritance," is not a kingdom that is "always spiritual" in the sense the definition requires. The author's exegesis, when he is actually reading Matthew, is better than his system.

Matthew 21:43 deserves one more word on its own account. Scripture defines the vineyard: "the vineyard of the LORD of hosts is the house of Israel" (Isa. 5:7). What Israel's leaders had, and were about to lose, Jesus calls "the kingdom of God." Ruckman explains that the kingdom "becomes the Kingdom of GOD" when it is taken from Israel.[29] But the verse calls it the kingdom of God *while they still held it*: "shall be taken from you." Set beside 1 Chronicles 28:5 and 2 Chronicles 13:8, the pattern is unbroken: the theocratic kingdom entrusted to Israel was, from Solomon to Caiaphas, the kingdom of God.

[28]Ruckman, *Book of Matthew*, on Matt. 21:31 and 21:33–37.

[29]Ruckman, *Sure Word of Prophecy*, chap. 7.

The kingdom of God is itself future, visible, and earthly

So far the evidence has been defensive: the proof texts do not prove the definitions. There is also positive evidence that Jesus and the apostles use "kingdom of God" for the literal, visible kingdom yet to come, and if so the phrase cannot be reserved for a spiritual one.

"There shall be weeping and gnashing of teeth, when ye shall see Abraham, and Isaac, and Jacob, and all the prophets, in the kingdom of God, and you yourselves thrust out. And they shall come from the east, and from the west, and from the north, and from the south, and shall sit down in the kingdom of God" (Luke 13:28–29). Seeing, sitting down, coming from the four points of the compass: this is a banquet on the earth, and it is the kingdom of God.

"He added and spake a parable, because he was nigh to Jerusalem, and because they thought that the kingdom of God should immediately appear" (Luke 19:11). Jesus does not correct the expectation that the kingdom of God would *appear*; He corrects the timing, with a parable of a nobleman who "went into a far country to receive for himself a kingdom, and to return" (19:12), and who on his return rewards his servants with cities and slays his enemies (19:15–27). Ruckman's commentary on Luke meets this verse honestly. "The kingdom of God cometh not with observation," he writes, "doesn't mean it will never come 'with observation,'" and at the Second Advent "men will finally be able to see the spiritual kingdom because there is a whole race of glorified and resurrected beings like the King walking around in plain sight."[30] That is the right reading of Luke 19, and it should be noticed what it costs. If "spiritual" now means "spiritual in nature, entered by the new birth, and visibly manifested when the King returns," then the Davidic kingdom promised to Israel is spiritual in exactly that sense, since it too is entered by conversion (Matt. 18:3) and by the new heart of Ezekiel 36, and it too is

[30]Ruckman, *Book of Luke*, chap. 19, on Luke 19:11–12.

manifested at the return. A definition that fits both kingdoms equally cannot be what tells them apart.

"And then shall they see the Son of man coming in a cloud with power and great glory. . . . when ye see these things come to pass, know ye that the kingdom of God is nigh at hand" (Luke 21:27, 31). The kingdom of God is "nigh at hand" when the Son of man is seen coming in the clouds.

"I will not any more eat thereof, until it be fulfilled in the kingdom of God. . . . I will not drink of the fruit of the vine, until the kingdom of God shall come. . . . I appoint unto you a kingdom, as my Father hath appointed unto me; That ye may eat and drink at my table in my kingdom, and sit on thrones judging the twelve tribes of Israel" (Luke 22:16, 18, 29–30). The kingdom of God is a kingdom that will "come," in which there is eating and drinking and thrones over the twelve tribes.

"There be some of them that stand here, which shall not taste of death, till they have seen the kingdom of God come with power" (Mark 9:1). Six days later Peter, James, and John saw the Son of man transfigured, His face shining as the sun, with Moses and Elijah, and Peter later called it "the power and coming of our Lord Jesus Christ" of which they "were eyewitnesses of his majesty" (2 Pet. 1:16). What they saw was a preview in visible glory, and Mark calls it the kingdom of God come with power. Matthew's record of the same promise calls it "the Son of man coming in his kingdom" (Matt. 16:28).

The apostles use the phrase the same way. "We must through much tribulation enter into the kingdom of God" (Acts 14:22). "The unrighteous shall not inherit the kingdom of God" (1 Cor. 6:9; cf. Gal. 5:21). Believers suffer "that ye may be counted worthy of the kingdom of God," a worthiness to be vindicated "when the Lord Jesus shall be revealed from heaven with his

mighty angels" (2 Thess. 1:5, 7). Paul "expounded and testified the kingdom of God . . . both out of the law of Moses, and out of the prophets" (Acts 28:23), which means the kingdom of God he preached was the kingdom the law and the prophets promised. When the seventh trumpet sounds, "the kingdoms of this world are become the kingdoms of our Lord, and of his Christ" (Rev. 11:15), and heaven cries, "Now is come salvation, and strength, and the kingdom of our God, and the power of his Christ" (12:10). The kingdom "of our God" arrives with the overthrow of the world's kingdoms.

From the other side, Matthew's "kingdom of heaven" is equally a kingdom of glory and thrones: "when the Son of man shall sit in the throne of his glory, ye also shall sit upon twelve thrones, judging the twelve tribes of Israel" (Matt. 19:28), and "Then shall the King say unto them on his right hand, Come, ye blessed of my Father, inherit the kingdom prepared for you" (25:34). The future kingdom is called by both names; the present, inward entrance is described under both names; the parables of the interval are told under both names. The two phrases run together from beginning to end.

Acts 1:3–7

The two-kingdom teaching leans heavily on Acts 1, and it is right about the most important thing there. The disciples asked, "Lord, wilt thou at this time restore again the kingdom to Israel?" (1:6). Its teachers argue, correctly, that this was not a carnal or ignorant question: it came from men who had just had forty days of instruction from the risen Lord, whose "understanding" He had opened "that they might understand the scriptures" (Luke 24:45); it was grounded in the prophets; and Jesus corrected only its timing ("It is not for you to know the times or the seasons") and not its substance. That is a strong argument for the literal kingdom, and it stands.

But the same teachers also read the passage as showing both kingdoms side by side: Jesus taught the kingdom of God for forty days, and the disciples, not satisfied with that, asked about the other one, the kingdom of heaven. The text says something simpler. For forty days Jesus spoke "of the things pertaining to the kingdom of God" (1:3); "When they *therefore* were come together, they asked of him" about restoring the kingdom to Israel (1:6). The "therefore" ties the question to the teaching. Forty days of instruction about the kingdom of God produced a question about Israel's restoration because Israel's restoration was part of what the kingdom of God is, which is exactly how Paul preached it, "out of the law of Moses, and out of the prophets" (28:23). There is no second kingdom hiding in Acts 1; there is one kingdom, and a question about when its visible, national form would come.

Where the other teachers stand

It is worth seeing that "the distinction" is not one position. The men who have distinguished the two phrases define them in different and sometimes opposite ways, and their disagreements are themselves evidence that the distinction is not being read off the text.

Scofield taught that the kingdom of heaven is "the Messianic earth rule of Jesus Christ, the Son of David," derived from Daniel, covenanted to David's seed, and having three aspects in Matthew: "at hand," in mystery during the present age, and in glory at the return.[31] He listed five differences from the kingdom of God, chief among them that the kingdom of God "is entered only by the new birth" while the kingdom of heaven "during this age, is the sphere of a profession which may be real or false," and that the kingdom of God is "chiefly that which is inward and spiritual" while the kingdom of heaven "is organic, and is to be manifested in glory on the earth." But he also wrote, in the same note, "Since the kingdom of heaven is the earthly

[31]Scofield, *Scofield Reference Bible*, note on Matt. 3:2, 996.

sphere of the universal kingdom of God, the two have almost all things in common. For this reason many parables and other teachings are spoken of the kingdom of heaven in Matthew, and of the kingdom of God in Mark and Luke."[32] For Scofield the two overlap almost entirely, and the kingdom of heaven is inside the kingdom of God as its earthly sphere.

Larkin agreed that the kingdom of God is "the 'Reign of God' in the Universe over all His created creatures," spiritual, entered by the new birth, and that the kingdom of heaven is found in Matthew only, thirty-two times. But then he defined the kingdom of heaven as "limited as to its Time and its Sphere. Its Time is from the First to the Second Coming of Christ, and its Sphere is over that part of the world that we call Christendom."[33] This is nearly the reverse of Ruckman. For Larkin, the *present mixed age* is the kingdom of heaven. Ironside says the same of the Matthew 13 parables: the kingdom of heaven "is really synonymous with what we commonly call Christendom," and he treats Luke's "kingdom of God" parables of the mustard seed and leaven as the same teaching.[34] In his own Bible margin he called the kingdom of heaven "a dispensational aspect of the Kingdom of God."[35] Chafer defined the kingdom of God as unlimited in extent and the kingdom of heaven as "the divine government in the earth," containing tares and bad fish, but he conceded at the outset: "There can be no question that there is much in common between whatever may be represented by these two terms, else they would not be used interchangeably."[36] McGee called the kingdom of God "a broader term that encompasses all of God's creation, including angels," and the kingdom of heaven "a progressive

[32]Scofield, *Scofield Reference Bible*, note on Matt. 6:33, 1003.

[33]Clarence Larkin, *Dispensational Truth, or God's Plan and Purpose in the Ages* (Philadelphia: Clarence Larkin Estate, 1918), "The Kingdom."

[34]H. A. Ironside, *Addresses on the Gospel of Luke* (New York: Loizeaux Brothers, 1947), 450 (Address 51, "Two Aspects of the Kingdom of God").

[35]Ironside, *Dr. Ironside's Bible*, 134 (note on Matt. 3:2).

[36]Lewis Sperry Chafer, *The Kingdom in History and Prophecy* (New York: Fleming H. Revell, 1915), chap. 5, "The Kingdom Rejected and Postponed."

term" that "assumes the mystery form during the days of the rejection of the King."[37] Walvoord treated the kingdom of heaven as the sphere of profession and the kingdom of God as the sphere of reality, admitted that "in some contexts they seem to be used synonymously," and insisted that the question is "purely an exegetical problem" and not a test of dispensationalism.[38]

Bullinger's treatment is the most careful of the older ones. He held that Jesus spoke identical words on every occasion, and that Matthew "was Divinely guided to retain the figure of speech literally ('heaven'), so as to be in keeping with the special character, design, and scope of his Gospel; while, in the other Gospels, the figure was translated as being what it also meant, 'the Kingdom of God.'" He therefore says the two are "the same in a general sense," though "to be distinguished in their meaning and in their interpretation": the kingdom of heaven Messianic, political, Jewish, and dispensational; the kingdom of God moral, spiritual, universal, and eternal.[39]

Set these side by side and the picture is plain. Ruckman says the present mystery form is the kingdom of God and not the kingdom of heaven. Larkin, Ironside, and Scofield say the present mystery form is precisely the kingdom of heaven. Scofield and Chafer put the kingdom of heaven *inside* the kingdom of God as its earthly sphere; Ruckman makes them two crowns held separately. Bullinger says the Lord spoke the same words every time. Ruckman regarded Scofield and McClain as having "failed to grasp the original plan."[40] These men cannot all be reading the distinction out of the text, because the text would then say one thing. What they share

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[37]J. Vernon McGee, *Matthew: Notes and Outlines* (Pasadena, CA: Thru the Bible Radio, n.d.), on the theme of Matthew.

[38]John F. Walvoord, "The Kingdom of Heaven," *Bibliotheca Sacra* 124, no. 495 (July–September 1967): 195–205; the two quotations come from the article's closing paragraphs.

[39]Bullinger, *Companion Bible*, Appendix 114.

[40]Ruckman, *Sure Word of Prophecy*, chap. 4.

is a true conviction, that Israel's kingdom is literal and future and that the church is not it, and a felt need for two labels to carry that conviction. The labels are what the text does not supply.

On the other side stand men who hold the literal kingdom no less firmly and who say the two phrases are synonyms. McClain's *Greatness of the Kingdom* organizes the whole subject around the universal kingdom and the mediatorial kingdom, the latter God's rule through a divinely chosen man, and finds no need for the two-term distinction.[41] Tim Miller, surveying the literature, observes that the older writers who taught a real difference in reference (he lists Scofield, Walvoord, Darby, Larkin, Chafer, Feinberg, and the early Ryrie) have largely been abandoned on this point by later dispensationalists (Saucy, Toussaint, McClain, and the later Ryrie), and that Matthew 19:23–24 did the most to change minds: Matthew "mentions both, connecting them with 'again I say to you,' signaling a repetition of the same idea."[42] Constable's notes are blunt: "This distinction has been shown to be invalid. One cannot make this distinction on the basis of how the New Testament writers used these terms."[43] Mayhue, introducing a journal issue on the kingdom, states simply that the two phrases "are used interchangeably by Matthew (19:23–24)" and lays out the kingdom under three heads: universal, mediatorial, and spiritual or redemptive, any one or several of which a given passage may have in view.[44] Every one of these writers is a premillennial dispensationalist. The synonymy of the terms and the literalness of Israel's kingdom are not in competition.

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[41]Alva J. McClain, *The Greatness of the Kingdom: An Inductive Study of the Kingdom of God* (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 1959).

[42]Tim Miller, "Kingdoms in Conflict: Examining the Use of 'Kingdom of Heaven' in Matthew," Maranatha Baptist Seminary, https://www.mbu.edu/seminary/kingdoms-in-conflict-examining-the-use-of-kingdom-of-heaven-in-matthew/. Miller cites Stanley D. Toussaint, *Behold the King: A Study of Matthew* (Grand Rapids: Kregel, 2005), 65, and Charles C. Ryrie, *Dispensationalism*, rev. ed. (Chicago: Moody, 2007), 154–57.

[43]Thomas L. Constable, *Notes on Matthew*, 2026 ed. (Sonic Light), note on Matt. 3:2, https://soniclight.com/tcon/notes/html/matthew/matthew.htm.

[44]Richard L. Mayhue, "The Kingdom of God: An Introduction," *The Master's Seminary Journal* 23, no. 2 (Fall 2012): 168, 170.

What Jesus offered, what was postponed, and what is present now

With the vocabulary settled, the second question, how the kingdom actually operates across the ages, can be answered from the same texts, and the answer keeps everything the two-kingdom teaching was trying to protect.

The kingdom Jesus offered was the kingdom the prophets promised

Gabriel told Mary, "the Lord God shall give unto him the throne of his father David: And he shall reign over the house of Jacob for ever; and of his kingdom there shall be no end" (Luke 1:32–33). John and Jesus announced that kingdom as "at hand" (Matt. 3:2; 4:17), that is, as having drawn near, without stopping to define it, because their hearers already knew from Daniel what the God of heaven had promised to set up. The Twelve were sent "to the lost sheep of the house of Israel" and to no one else with that message (Matt. 10:5–7). The crowds cried, "Blessed be the kingdom of our father David, that cometh in the name of the Lord" (Mark 11:10). Jesus promised the Twelve "twelve thrones, judging the twelve tribes of Israel" (Matt. 19:28). Nothing in the record suggests that Israel was offered anything other than the literal Davidic kingdom of the prophets. Scofield's remark is exact: "They were never rebuked for expecting a visible and powerful kingdom, but the words of the prophets should have prepared them to expect also that only the poor in spirit and the meek could share in it."[45]

At the same time, the kingdom's power was already at work in the King. "If I cast out devils by the Spirit of God, then the kingdom of God is come unto you" (Matt. 12:28); "is come unto you" is arrival, not approach. The entrance requirement was proclaimed from the first word: "Repent" (Matt. 3:2; 4:17), "Except ye be converted" (18:3), "Except a man be born again" (John

[45]Scofield, *Scofield Reference Bible*, note on Matt. 5:2, 1000.

3:3). This was not a spiritual kingdom offered in place of a physical one. It was the one kingdom of Ezekiel 36, new heart and land together, offered to the nation in the person of its King.

The rejection and the postponement

Israel's leaders rejected the King (Matt. 12:14, 24; 21:43; 23:37–39), and Jesus said the visible kingdom would wait: "Ye shall not see me henceforth, till ye shall say, Blessed is he that cometh in the name of the Lord" (23:39). The nobleman "went into a far country to receive for himself a kingdom, and to return" (Luke 19:12). Heaven must receive Him "until the times of restitution of all things, which God hath spoken by the mouth of all his holy prophets" (Acts 3:21). "Blindness in part is happened to Israel, until the fulness of the Gentiles be come in. And so all Israel shall be saved" (Rom. 11:25–26). The word "until" governs the whole period. The Davidic, visible form of the kingdom is postponed, not cancelled, and not transferred to the church.

Two cautions keep this from being overstated. First, the cross was not an adjustment forced on God by the rejection. Christ was "delivered by the determinate counsel and foreknowledge of God" (Acts 2:23), and "thus it behoved Christ to suffer, and to rise from the dead the third day" (Luke 24:46). The offer was genuine and the rejection was culpable, but the suffering of the Messiah before His glory was written in the prophets before the offer was made. Second, Scripture does not narrate what would have happened had the nation received Him. Speculation on that point is not exegesis, and the argument of this paper does not depend on it.

The present form of the kingdom

Meanwhile, the kingdom of God is real in every believer. God "hath delivered us from the power of darkness, and hath translated us into the kingdom of his dear Son" (Col. 1:13). That is a completed transfer, in the past tense, into a kingdom whose King is Christ. Its character now

is "righteousness, and peace, and joy in the Holy Ghost" (Rom. 14:17), and its power is "not in word, but in power" (1 Cor. 4:20). Believers are in it and are also "heirs of the kingdom which he hath promised to them that love him" (James 2:5), which means the same kingdom has a present possession and a future inheritance. Christ is now seated "with my Father in his throne" (Rev. 3:21), not yet on "the throne of his glory" (Matt. 25:31); the distinction between the Father's throne now and the Son's own throne then is the Bible's own way of marking the two stages. Believers do not reign yet, but "if we suffer, we shall also reign with him" (2 Tim. 2:12), and they will, for a thousand years (Rev. 20:4–6).

It is more exact to say that the Spirit dwells in believers (Rom. 8:9) and that believers are in Christ's kingdom (Col. 1:13) than to say that the kingdom is located inside them. That is what the two-kingdom teaching reaches for when it speaks of Christ reigning "on the throne of our hearts," and as devotion the phrase is harmless; as a definition it puts the kingdom in the wrong place. The King is on a throne in heaven, His people are in His kingdom on earth, and the Spirit who seals them is within.

The future and eternal forms

When He returns, "The kingdoms of this world are become the kingdoms of our Lord, and of his Christ" (Rev. 11:15). He sits on the throne of His glory (Matt. 25:31), the Twelve sit on theirs (19:28), the saints reign with Him a thousand years (Rev. 20:4–6), and Israel, regathered and regenerated, dwells in her land under David's Son (Ezek. 37:21–25). This is the kingdom of God visibly come (Luke 19:11; 21:31), and it is the kingdom of heaven manifested in glory (Matt. 25:31–34). Then "cometh the end, when he shall have delivered up the kingdom to God, even the Father; when he shall have put down all rule and all authority and power" (1 Cor. 15:24), and the kingdom continues as "the everlasting kingdom of our Lord and Saviour

Jesus Christ" (2 Pet. 1:11) in the new heaven and the new earth. The future kingdom is earthly and spiritual in character at once, as the prophets said it would be. The present reign is real before that public fulfillment.

Definitions, and better names for the two things being distinguished

The following definitions are offered as the ones the text will bear.

The kingdom of God is the rule of God, and the realm and people under that rule. Scripture uses the expression for every phase of His reign: His universal rule over all things (Ps. 103:19; Dan. 4:34); the theocratic kingdom entrusted to Israel under David's house (1 Chron. 28:5; 2 Chron. 13:8; Matt. 21:43); its mystery form between the advents, told in the same parables and figures as Matthew 13 (Mark 4:11–32; Luke 8:10; 13:18–21); its present form, in which Christ reigns over born-again believers by the Holy Ghost, entered by the new birth and marked by righteousness, peace, and joy (John 3:3–5; Rom. 14:17; Col. 1:13); its future visible form, when Christ reigns on the earth from David's throne (Luke 13:28–29; 19:11–27; 21:31; 22:16–30); and its eternal form (1 Cor. 15:24–28; 2 Pet. 1:11). Context, not the phrase, tells which phase is in view.

The kingdom of heaven is Matthew's name for the same kingdom of God, presenting it as heaven's rule coming to the earth: the kingdom "the God of heaven" promised to set up in place of the Gentile kingdoms (Dan. 2:44; 7:27), covenanted to David's Son. In Matthew it is announced as "at hand" and offered to Israel (3:2–12:50); it takes a "mystery" form between the advents, the whole sphere of profession in which true and false grow together until the harvest (13:11–52; 16:19; 20:1–16); it passes through the Tribulation with its guests, its waiting virgins, and its reckoned servants (22:8–14; 25:1–30); and it is manifested when "the Son of man shall come in his glory" and sits "upon the throne of his glory" (25:31–34).

How they relate. Two names for one kingdom. Every kingdom-of-heaven passage is a kingdom-of-God passage, though not every kingdom-of-God passage is spoken in Matthew's heaven-to-earth terms, since "kingdom of God" also covers God's universal rule and, in the epistles, the believer's present standing and future inheritance.

If the aim is to keep separate the literal kingdom promised to Israel and the spiritual reign of Christ in believers, the Bible supplies better names than "kingdom of heaven" and "kingdom of God," and they should be used instead. The literal kingdom is "the kingdom . . . to Israel" (Acts 1:6), "the throne of his father David" (Luke 1:32), "the kingdom of our father David" (Mark 11:10), "the throne of his glory" (Matt. 19:28; 25:31), "the kingdom of the LORD over Israel" (1 Chron. 28:5); in theological shorthand, the Davidic, messianic, or millennial kingdom, or in McClain's terms the mediatorial kingdom in its final form. The present spiritual reign is "the kingdom of his dear Son" (Col. 1:13), the kingdom of God as "righteousness, and peace, and joy in the Holy Ghost" (Rom. 14:17), or in Matthew's terms the kingdom in mystery; in shorthand, the present form of the kingdom of God. God's rule over everything, always, is "his kingdom ruleth over all" (Ps. 103:19), the universal kingdom. And the final state is "the everlasting kingdom" (2 Pet. 1:11), the eternal kingdom. These labels have the advantage of being the Bible's own, and of not requiring anyone to explain away a parallel passage.

The strongest objections, answered

"Things different are not equal. God is not heaven." True of the objects, false of the idiom. The sky is not God; but Scripture uses "heaven" for God's ruling authority (Dan. 4:25–26; Luke 15:18; Matt. 21:25; John 3:27), and different words routinely name one thing from different sides, as "Son of man" and "Son of God" name one Christ. What settles the reference of

a phrase is not its spelling but the Bible's own usage in parallel records, and that usage is uniform.

"The phrases only look interchangeable because the King of both kingdoms was present." This explains the "at hand" texts, if two kingdoms are granted in the first place. It does not explain the future, visible kingdom-of-God passages (Luke 13:28–29; 19:11; 21:31; 22:16–30; Mark 9:1), or the inward, moral kingdom-of-heaven passages (Matt. 5:3, 20; 18:3; 23:13), or the epistles' future "inherit the kingdom of God" written long after the King had ascended. Nor does it explain Luke 16:16. Ruckman's commentary on that verse draws a line at John's death: John and Jesus "start out their ministries" preaching the kingdom of heaven, "but now that John is gone, the Kingdom of Heaven assumes a mystery form . . . and it is the spiritual kingdom—the Kingdom of God—that Jesus Christ and the disciples preach."[46] The chronology of the Gospels will not allow that line. Jesus preached "the kingdom of God" from the beginning of His Galilean ministry, while John was in prison but alive (Mark 1:14–15; Luke 4:43); when John's disciples came from the prison with their question, Jesus' answer about John is recorded with "the kingdom of heaven" in Matthew 11:11 and "the kingdom of God" in Luke 7:28; the commission of the Twelve is "The kingdom of heaven is at hand" in Matthew 10:7 and "to preach the kingdom of God" in Luke 9:2; and Matthew has Jesus still speaking of "the kingdom of heaven" long after John was gone (18:3; 19:14, 23; 23:13). The two phrases run side by side through the whole ministry. There is no date on which one replaced the other. And if both kingdoms also "meet" at the Second Coming, as Ruckman's Matthew commentary says, then every future kingdom text is a "both" text as well, and "always spiritual" and "always physical" no longer do any work. A definition that has to be suspended whenever the King is on the scene is not a definition of the phrase.

[46]Ruckman, *Book of Luke*, chap. 16, on Luke 16:16.

"Tares and bad fish are only in the kingdom of heaven, so it must be the mixed, earthly sphere." Scofield built his version of the distinction on this omission: "The parables of the wheat and tares, and of the net . . . are not spoken of the kingdom of God. In that kingdom there are neither tares nor bad fish."[47] Ruckman repeats it.[48] But Scofield had to admit in the same note that the leaven "is spoken of the kingdom of God also" (Luke 13:20–21); the sower, with its wayside, stony, and thorny hearers, is a "mystery of the kingdom of God" in Mark 4:11 and Luke 8:10; and Luke's kingdom of God has "workers of iniquity" thrust out of it (13:27–28) exactly as Matthew's has "the children of the kingdom" cast out (8:12). Only the tares and the net are unique to Matthew, and Mark and Luke omit most of Matthew 13. Moreover, Jesus says what the tares are: "The field is the world; the good seed are the children of the kingdom; but the tares are the children of the wicked one" (Matt. 13:38). They are the devil's children, not the King's, sown among the wheat in the world and gathered out of His kingdom only at the harvest (13:41). The parable describes the kingdom's condition in the world during the King's absence, not its membership roll. Ruckman himself grants that the two "are identical in three parables: the sower, the mustard seed, and the leaven."[49]

"Revelation 11:15 says 'kingdoms,' plural: there is more than one kingdom." Some who teach the distinction make this argument from the wording of the verse. But the plural belongs to "the kingdoms of this world," which "are become the kingdoms of our Lord, and of his Christ." The many kingdoms are the world's kingdoms, Babylon's successors down to the last, which all pass to one Lord who "shall reign for ever and ever." The verse describes many earthly kingdoms becoming one Lord's; it says nothing about two divine kingdoms. The second "kingdoms,"

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[47]Scofield, *Scofield Reference Bible*, note on Matt. 6:33, 1003.

[48]Ruckman, *Book of Matthew*, on Matt. 6:33.

[49]Ruckman, *Book of Matthew*, on Matt. 13:4–9.

moreover, stands in italics, supplied by the translators; the only "kingdoms" the text itself names are the world's.

"Righteousness goes with the kingdom of God, not the kingdom of heaven." Matthew 5:20 attaches righteousness to entering the kingdom of heaven before 6:33 attaches it to seeking the kingdom of God. The Sermon joins righteousness to both names of the one kingdom.

"If the phrases are the same, the literal kingdom for Israel has been surrendered to amillennialism." No. McClain, Toussaint, Constable, Mayhue, the later Ryrie, and many others treat the terms as synonyms and teach a literal, postponed, millennial Davidic kingdom for Israel. That kingdom rests on the covenant with David and on Luke 1:32–33, Acts 1:6–7, Acts 3:19–21, Romans 11, and Revelation 20, not on the spelling of "heaven." Ruckman's real quarrel is with Rome and the Reformers, who equated the phrases *and also* denied Israel her kingdom and merged the church with it. The remedy for that error is to hold the promises literally, not to build a second kingdom out of an idiom.

Conclusion

Measured by the words of Scripture, the two-kingdom teaching is right about the large things and wrong about the labels. It is right that the theme of the Bible is a King and His kingdom, right that there is a literal, earthly, Davidic kingdom promised to Israel and not cancelled or handed to the church, right that it was offered at Christ's first coming, rejected, and postponed to His second, right that Matthew is a Jewish and transitional book whose kingdom teaching is first of all about Israel, right that the disciples' question in Acts 1:6 was sound, and right that the new birth is the only door into God's kingdom in any age. Every one of those points has been affirmed here.

It is wrong to say that the kingdom of God is always spiritual, because Scripture places Abraham and the prophets in it at a visible banquet, has the Lord eating and drinking in it, says it will appear and come with power, and calls David's throne and Israel's vineyard the kingdom of God. It is wrong to say that the kingdom of heaven is always physical, because Matthew calls the present mystery stage by that name, describes its seed as sown in the heart, and has men entering it by conversion while the scribes shut the door. And it is wrong to confine the kingdom of heaven to a Jewish national kingdom on the earth, because Matthew's own uses of the phrase run from the offer to Israel through the Gentiles at Abraham's table, the whole history of Christendom, and the keys that opened the door to the Gentiles, to the Tribulation and the King on the throne of His glory. It is wrong to say the two are never the same, because the Holy Ghost recorded the same sayings on the same occasions under both names and Matthew changed names in the middle of one warning. It is wrong to say there was no kingdom of God from Adam to Christ, because the Chronicles say Solomon sat on the throne of the kingdom of the LORD. And it is wrong to say that "heaven" can never stand for God, because Daniel wrote "the heavens do rule" and meant "the most High ruleth."

The real distinction is not between two kingdoms but between the phases of one. The King reigns now over a people He has translated into His kingdom by the new birth; He will reign then, visibly, from David's throne over Israel and the nations; and after that, for ever. The Bible has names for each of these, and none of them is "the kingdom of heaven versus the kingdom of God." A student who wants to rightly divide the word of truth will do better with the Bible's names than with the ones he was handed, and the willingness to make that exchange is itself one of the first rules of studying the Book.

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